

Of Blood and Crystal

Haemocratic Sovereignty, Tactical Heresy, and the Ludic Trauerspiel in Final Fantasy Tactics

A Dissertation

Of Blood and Crystal: Haemocratic Sovereignty, Tactical Heresy, and the Ludic Trauerspiel in Final Fantasy Tactics. First set October 2026.

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Final Fantasy Tactics and all associated names are the property of their respective owners. This study is an independent work of criticism; dialogue from the game is paraphrased throughout.

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A Dissertation in Comparative Literature, Political Philosophy, and Game Studies

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Abstract

This dissertation argues that *Final Fantasy Tactics* (Square, 1997; direction and scenario by Yasumi Matsuno, game design by Hiroyuki Ito, production by Hironobu Sakaguchi) is not a political fantasy that merely borrows the furniture of late-medieval Europe, but a systematic philosophical work whose narrative, mechanics, and frame-apparatus converge upon an original theory of how communities dispose of their dead, and of how the dead might be withheld from the victors who would use them. The argument proceeds through four orders, Blood, Stone, Grid, and Record, which correspond respectively to political philosophy, political theology, ludic form, and historiography.

Under the order of Blood, Ivalice is reconstructed as a *haemocracy*: a polity whose legitimacy circulates through blood in two registers, the *lineal* (heredity, the blood of nobility) and the *effusive* (the blood shed in war and sacrifice). The crisis that follows the Fifty Years' War is read as the failure of lineal blood at the summit of the realm (a dead king, an infant heir, a princess whose royal blood her own captors deny) and the consequent mobilization of effusive blood as the only remaining source of legitimacy. Delita Heiral is reconstructed as an *Agathoclean prince*, after the eighth chapter of Machiavelli's *Prince*: a figure who acquires *imperio* without *gloria*, and whose realm inverts Kant's Kingdom of Ends into a Kingdom of Means. Ovelia, Tietra, and Alma are read as the vicarious bodies through which Ivalician sovereignty speaks, with Kantorowicz, Hobbesian personation, the Japanese *kagemusha*, and the anthropology of exchange.

Under the order of Stone, the Glabados Church is read through Hobbes's image of the papacy as the ghost of a deceased empire, Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, Simmel's *tertius gaudens*, and Schmitt's political theology; the Germonik Scriptures through the Judas traditions from Irenaeus to Borges and Endō, Lorenzo Valla's philology, Jan Assmann's mnemohistory, Girard's scapegoat, and Gnostic cosmology; the Zodiac Stones and the Lucavi through Weber's diabolical powers and resurgent disenchanted gods, the Faustian pact, Miura's *Berserk*, and Benjamin's critique of mythic violence.

Under the order of the Grid, the game's systems (Charge Time, Faith and Bravery, the job system, speechcraft, zodiac compatibility, and the crystallization of the fallen) are treated as propositions co-equal with the narrative, read through Michel de Certeau's distinction between strategy and tactics, Deleuze and Guattari's war machine, Pico della Mirandola's *Oration*, Bergson and Benjamin on homogeneous time, Arendt on administrative violence, Simone Weil on force, and Heidegger and Derrida on inheritance. Under the order of Re-

cord, the Durai Papers are read with Benjamin's theses on history, Nietzsche's three modes of history, Hayden White's theory of emplotment, Arendt's "Truth and Politics," de Certeau's account of historiography as burial, Josephine Tey's revision of the Tudor myth, and the Japanese traditions of the *Heike monogatari*, Orikuchi Shinobu's *kishu ryūri tan*, and *hōganbiiki*.

The dissertation's original contribution is the synthesis these readings make possible. *Final Fantasy Tactics* opposes two lithic regimes. The *petrific*, embodied in the Zodiac Stones, converts persons into vessels, saints, and monuments, and hoards them as power. The *crystalline*, embodied in the crystals the fallen leave upon the battlefield, converts the dead into transmissible capacities that a living inheritor must choose to take up. From this opposition I derive a theory of *crystalline historicity*: a relation to the past in which the dead are neither resurrected (the Lucavi), nor commodified (the treasure chest), nor monumentalized (the official chronicle), but inherited as capacity. I argue further that the game realizes this theory in an unprecedented form, the *ludic Trauerspiel*: a mourning-play, in Benjamin's sense, that positions its player as the very intriguer its narrative indicts, so that to play well is to rehearse the sovereign's gaze, and to finish is to be asked, with Delita, what one has gained. Between the two regimes stands the tactical subject, Ramza Beoulve, whose heresy is not a counter-doctrine but a practice without a proper place. The study concludes with eighteen theses on the crystallization of history.

Note on Texts

Translations, Nomenclature, and Citation

The primary text is *Fainaru Fantajī Takutikusu* (Square, Sony PlayStation; released in Japan on 20 June 1997 and in North America in January 1998), together with its revised edition, *Final Fantasy Tactics: The War of the Lions* (Square Enix, PlayStation Portable, 2007; Japanese subtitle *Shishi Sensō*, "The Lion War"), and the remaster *Final Fantasy Tactics: The Ivalice Chronicles* (Square Enix, 2025). The three releases share a plot but not a script, and the remaster itself contains two: a Classic mode that pairs the 1997 Japanese script with the 2007 English one, and an Enhanced mode whose script Matsuno revised throughout for full voicing. Where they diverge in ways that bear on interpretation, the divergence is treated as evidence rather than noise (Chapter 11).

Proper names follow the 2007 retranslation, with the 1998 English forms given on first mention where they differ: Delacroix (Draclau), Folmarv (Vormav), Funebris (Funeral), Barbaneth (Balbanes), Argath (Algus), Milleuda (Miluda), Tietra (Teta), Gaffgarion (Gafgarion), Louveria (Ruvelia), Isilud (Izlude), Eagrose (Igros), Zeakden (Ziekden), Mullonde (Murond), the Death Corps (Corpse Brigade), the Knights Templar (Shrine Knights), the Order of the Northern Sky (Hokuten), the Order of the Southern Sky (Nanten), the Zodiac Stones or auracite (Holy Stones), Arithmetician (Calculator), Orator (Mediator), speechcraft (Talk Skill). One exception is made: the suppressed gospel keeps its 1998 name, the Germonik Scriptures (2007: Scriptures of Germonique). The historian of the frame is cited as Alazlam J. Durai (1998: Arazlam), descendant of Orran Durai (1998: Olan), author of the record he recovers; that record is cited as the *Durai Papers* (1998: *Durai Report*; Japanese *Durai hakusho*, literally the "Durai White Paper").

Dialogue is paraphrased rather than quoted. The decision is methodological as much as legal. With two English scripts of markedly different diction, and a third in the remaster, no verbatim line can claim to be *the* text, and an argument that hangs upon a translator's phrase is an argument about the translator. Mechanics are described as implemented in the original release; where a figure is cited (a threshold, a count, a probability's direction), it is the figure the systems themselves enforce.

Quotations from philosophical, scriptural, and literary sources are given in the original language where the original is in the public domain, followed by the author's own translation. Modern secondary sources are paraphrased and cited by author, short title, and date;

full references are collected under Works Cited. Credits are cited by function: Yasumi Matsuno (direction, scenario), Hiroyuki Ito (game design), Hironobu Sakaguchi (production), Akihiko Yoshida (character design), Hiroshi Minagawa (art direction), Hitoshi Sakimoto and Masaharu Iwata (music). Attributions of intent are confined to what is publicly documented. Every other genealogical claim that follows, whether about Machiavelli, Benjamin, Borges, or the *Heike*, is a claim about the ideas the text puts to work, not about what its makers read.

Contents

Abstract 4

Note on Texts, Translations, Nomenclature, and Citation 6

Introduction: The Historian's Wager 9

PART ONE *The Order of Blood* 15

1 Haemocracy: Ivalice after the Fifty Years' War 17

2 The Agathoclean Prince: Delita Heiral and the Grammar of Ascent 23

3 Vicarious Bodies: Ovelia, Tietra, Alma 29

PART TWO *The Order of Stone* 35

4 The Ghost of the Deceased Empire: The Glabados Church 37

5 The Gospel of the Traitor: The Germonik Scriptures 43

6 Constellations of the Pact: Zodiac Stones and Lucavi 49

PART THREE *The Order of the Grid* 55

7 The Art of the Weak: Tactics, Strategy, and the Placeless Hero 57

8 Chronopolitics: Charge Time and the Arithmetic of Death 63

9 The Scalar Subject: Faith, Bravery, and the Speech That Moves Them 67

10 The Triduum of the Count: Crystals, Chests, and the Economy of the Dead 73

PART FOUR *The Order of the Record* 79

11 The Chronicle of the Defeated: The Durai Papers and the Historiography of Ivalice 81

PART FIVE *Synthesis* 89

12 Theses on the Crystallization of History 91

Conclusion: "What Did You Get?" 95

Works Cited 97

Keywords 104

Introduction

The Historian's Wager

祇園精舎の鐘の声、諸行無常の響きあり。沙羅双樹の花の色、盛者必衰の理をあらはす。

The bell of the Gion Shōja sounds the impermanence of all things; the colour of the sāla blossoms declares the law that the flourishing must decline.

Heike monogatari, opening of the Kakuichi text, 1371

...auch die Toten werden vor dem Feind, wenn er siegt, nicht sicher sein. Und dieser Feind hat zu siegen nicht aufgehört.

Even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins. And this enemy has not ceased to win.

Walter Benjamin, "Über den Begriff der Geschichte," Thesis VI, 1940

Remota itaque iustitia quid sunt regna nisi magna latrocinia?

Justice removed, then, what are kingdoms but great robberies?

Augustine, *De civitate Dei* IV.4

I.1 Incipit: a game that begins with a historian

The first voice heard in *Final Fantasy Tactics* belongs not to a hero but to a historian. Before a single unit moves, the narrator of the frame, Alazlam Durai, addresses the player across an interval of centuries, rehearses the received memory of the Lion War (a commoner-hero, Delita Heiral, who ended it and ascended the throne of Ivalice), and then unsettles that memory by naming a figure it does not contain: Ramza Beoulve. The opening is a wager in the Pascalian sense. It stakes the whole work on the proposition that the received history is false, and that a counter-record, the papers of Orran Durai, can restore what the chronicle omitted. Everything playable thereafter is, formally, a reconstruction of that counter-record. The battles are not events but re-enactments in R. G. Collingwood's sense (*The Idea of History*, 1946), in which the historian re-thinks the thought of past agents; the difference is that here the re-thinking is performed, move by move, by the player.

This framing is without precedent in the series that lends the game its name, and it alters the ontology of play. In the role-playing game as the genre had developed by 1997, play pro-

duces events: the player's actions constitute the story's present. In *Final Fantasy Tactics*, play reproduces testimony. The player is cast less as protagonist than as a reader obliged to perform a document in order to read it, so that every victory confirms an account and every defeat is the momentary failure of a witness. The game's encyclopedic apparatus, the *Brave Story*, extends the logic: it accumulates the persons, events, artefacts, and rumours of the war as a chronicle that grows as the player advances, so that the act of play and the act of archiving coincide. The question the work poses is therefore not the familiar question of its genre (what will happen?) but the historiographer's question (what happened, who recorded it, and to what end?).

I.2 The argument

The thesis of this dissertation is that *Final Fantasy Tactics* is a philosophical work in the strong sense. It does not illustrate ideas borrowed from elsewhere; it advances, by means proper to its medium, a position on a question that political philosophy, theology, and historiography have each addressed only in part. The question is what a political community does with its dead. The position is that every polity reproduces itself through a determinate economy of the dead, and the game distinguishes three. The first is the *haemic* economy, in which the dead are blood: either the lineal blood of ancestry that legitimates the living, or the effusive blood of sacrifice that purchases legitimacy when ancestry fails. The second is the *petrific* economy, in which the dead are stone: vessels, relics, saints, and monuments, conserved and hoarded so that the living may draw upon them. The third is the *crystalline* economy, in which the dead are neither blood nor monument but capacity, a light left on the ground that a living successor may choose to take up at the cost of the consolation that the same light could have afforded.

Ivalice is governed by the first two economies; the third survives only on the battlefield and in a heretic's history. The Lucavi, who require the blood of a war to fashion a body for their sovereign, are the metaphysical truth of the haemic economy. The Glabados Church, which administers the relics and the legend of a saint, is the institutional truth of the petrific. Delita, who achieves by purely human means what the demons attempt by supernatural ones, is the proof that neither economy needs demons in order to function. Ramza, who renounces his blood, refuses the stones, and leaves behind nothing but the testimony of a friend, is the solitary bearer of the third. The game's mechanics, which convert every fallen unit after three counts into a crystal or a treasure chest, make the player administer all three economies at once, and so convert a narrative about history into an apparatus for experiencing what it costs to inherit it.

Two theoretical proposals follow. The first is a theory of *crystalline historicity*: a mode of relation to the past distinct from monumental commemoration, antiquarian piety, and even

critical judgement in Nietzsche's sense, because it understands the past as a reserve of capacities transmitted to those who choose to inherit them, rather than as a body of facts possessed or a pantheon revered. The second is the identification of a form, the *ludic Trauerspiel*, in which a work of play takes up the structure Walter Benjamin found in the German baroque mourning-play (the melancholy sovereign, the calculating intriguer, history as ruin and allegory) and binds its player to the position of the intriguer. The German compound already contains the argument. A *Trauerspiel* is a play (*Spiel*) of mourning (*Trauer*), and *Final Fantasy Tactics* is the first major work in which the play is literal.

I.3 Method: co-equal reading

The dissertation reads mechanics and narrative as co-equal bearers of argument. This places it athwart the quarrel that structured early game studies, in which narratological readings treated games as stories with obstacles, and ludological readings, after Gonzalo Frasca (1999) and Espen Aarseth (*Cybertext*, 1997), insisted on the irreducibility of rules. Jesper Juul's resolution (*Half-Real*, 2005), in which a game is at once a real set of rules and a fictional world, and Ian Bogost's account of procedural rhetoric (*Persuasive Games*, 2007), in which a rule system makes claims about the world it models, together license a stronger procedure: to treat a rule as a proposition. A system in which faith magnifies both the healing one receives and the harm one suffers says something about faith. A system in which the timid find rarer treasure says something about timidity. A system in which the dead become either an inheritance or a commodity at the toss of a hidden coin says something about the dead. These propositions are not ornaments of the story; they are arguments the story could not make alone.

The second commitment is genealogical rather than influential, in the sense Michel Foucault drew from Nietzsche ("Nietzsche, la généalogie, l'histoire," 1971). To call Machiavelli, Hobbes, Hegel, Benjamin, or the anonymous compilers of the *Heike* the originators of the ideas the game deploys is to trace a lineage of problems, not to assert that the development team read them. W. K. Wimsatt and Monroe Beardsley's caution against the intentional fallacy (1946) applies with special force to a collective work produced under commercial conditions. Where authorial statements are documented they are cited as such; elsewhere the claim is only that the ideas are present and doing work.

The third commitment is comparative across the boundary between European and Japanese traditions. *Final Fantasy Tactics* is a Japanese work that stages a recognizably European late Middle Ages (the Hundred Years' War, the Black Death, the Wars of the Roses, a militant Latin church), and it has been read in the Anglophone world almost exclusively through European analogues. Its narrative grammar is equally legible through Sengoku *gekokujō*, the armed monasteries of Mount Hiei and the Ikkō leagues, the elegiac historiography of the *Heike*, and the long Japanese sympathy for the noble failure. Much of the work's originality

lies in the fusion of these grammars, and a reading attentive to one alone misses the hinge on which the whole turns.

I.4 Authorship and lineage

Matsuno came to Square in 1995 from Quest, where he had directed *Ogre Battle: The March of the Black Queen* (1993) and *Tactics Ogre: Let Us Cling Together* (1995). The titles of both, borrowed from songs by the rock group Queen, establish a signature that recurs in *Final Fantasy Tactics*, whose original fourth chapter takes the title of Queen's "Somebody to Love" (1976). More substantively, *Tactics Ogre* organized its branching narrative around the alignments of Law, Neutrality, and Chaos, a cosmology descended from Michael Moorcock's Eternal Champion sequence through the tabletop role-playing games that popularized it. Its central atrocity, the massacre at Balmamusa, required the player to decide whether a political end justified the slaughter of one's own people under a false flag. *Final Fantasy Tactics* abolishes alignment as an elective route and internalizes it as a pair of mutable quantities, Faith and Bravery, carried by every unit (Chapter 9). The moral decision ceases to be a fork in the plot and becomes a property of persons, continuously modified by speech and experience.

Ito's contribution is the systemic architecture. As designer of the Active Time Battle system introduced in *Final Fantasy IV* (1991) and battle designer of *Final Fantasy V* (1992), whose job system made abilities transferable between vocations, he had already made time and vocation the two axes of the series' combat. *Final Fantasy Tactics* extends both into a tactical grid, as Charge Time and a lattice of twenty jobs (Chapters 7 and 8). The later careers of the two men complete the lineage. Matsuno's *Vagrant Story* (2000) and his original direction of *Final Fantasy XII* (2006), which Ito and Hiroshi Minagawa brought to completion after Matsuno's departure, return to Ivalice and to the question of who authors its history, as does Matsuno's "Return to Ivalice" sequence for *Final Fantasy XIV* (2017–2019), whose final installment restages Orbonne Monastery. Sakaguchi's role as producer supplies an irony the dissertation notes without pressing: the series' most sustained critique of institutional mythmaking was made under its institution's most valuable name. The visual and musical languages complete the text. Yoshida's elongated, manuscript-inflected figures and Minagawa's rotatable isometric fields give the world the look of an illuminated chronicle, while the scores of Sakimoto and Iwata alternate between the liturgical and the martial, as though church and army were competing for the same air.

I.5 Nineteen ninety-seven: a constellation

Benjamin's term for the relation between an idea and the phenomena that body it forth is the constellation: the figure that appears when scattered points are seen together (*Ursprung des deutschen Trauerspiels*, 1928). *Final Fantasy Tactics* appeared within a constellation worth

naming, not because its stars caused the work, though its author has named one of them among its inspirations, but because together they show that the questions it posed were being posed with unusual force at that moment.

In Japan, 1997 was a year of contested history. In August the Supreme Court decided the third and last of the textbook suits that the historian Ienaga Saburō had pursued against state screening of school histories since 1965, holding by three votes to two that the Ministry of Education had acted unlawfully in ordering the deletion of a passage on Unit 731, the Imperial Japanese Army unit that conducted lethal experiments on prisoners in occupied China, while upholding the screening system itself. At the turn of 1996 and 1997 the Japanese Society for History Textbook Reform organized to campaign against what its founders called a "masochistic" view of history, including the references to the military's "comfort women" that had entered all seven middle-school history textbooks approved for use from 1997. Testimony and official record had been in open conflict since August 1991, when women forced into sexual servitude in the Imperial Japanese military's "comfort stations" began to testify publicly, one of them under her own name, and since the Kōno Statement of August 1993, in which the Japanese government acknowledged that the military had been directly or indirectly involved in establishing and running the stations, that many of the women had been recruited against their will, and that they had lived in misery under coercion. Two years before the game's release, in March 1995, Aum Shinrikyō, a religious organization equipped with a quasi-state ministerial structure, a weapons programme, and an apocalyptic theology, had released sarin on the Tokyo subway on the orders of its leader, Asahara Shōkō, killing thirteen people and injuring more than 5,800. In November 1997 the collapse of Yamaichi Securities deepened the economic aftermath of the bubble. Matsuno has since said that the collapse of Japan's economy in the 1990s was among the story's inspirations, and in offering it again in 2025 he described a society in which inequality and division remain deeply rooted. A game about a church that engineers a war, a nobility that cannot pay its veterans, and a history falsified by its victors reached its first players in that world.

Elsewhere, the same year saw Jan Assmann's *Moses the Egyptian*, which named the study of the past as remembered *mnemohistory*; the first printing of Foucault's 1976 lectures *Il faut défendre la société*, a genealogy of counter-history as the discourse of the vanquished; Aarseth's *Cybertext* and Janet Murray's *Hamlet on the Holodeck*, founding books of game and digital-narrative studies; Philip Pullman's *The Subtle Knife*, the middle volume of a trilogy in which a church serves an angel who has usurped the name of God; Hayao Miyazaki's *Princess Mononoke*, in which firearms emancipate the outcast labourers of an ironworks while an emperor's agents hunt a god's head; the first anime adaptation of Miura Kentarō's *Berserk*, whose commoner-prince sacrifices his comrades to demons in exchange for a kingdom; and Anno Hideaki's *The End of Evangelion*, in which a secret council engineers the dissolution of

humanity into a single being in the name of its completion. George R. R. Martin's *A Game of Thrones*, a Wars of the Roses transposed into fantasy, had appeared the year before. None of these is a source. All of them are coordinates.

I.6 Five concepts

Five concepts organize what follows. *Haemocracy* names the polity whose legitimacy circulates through blood in the two registers already described, and whose crises take the form of substitutions of effusive for lineal blood. *Petrification* and *crystallization* name the two lithic regimes in which the dead may be kept: the stone that imprisons a power and awaits a host, and the crystal that releases a capacity and awaits an heir. *Tactical heresy*, after de Certeau, names a mode of agency exercised without a proper place, on the terrain of another, leaving no institution behind; Ramza's heresy consists not in holding another doctrine but in this practice. *Vicarious sovereignty* names the condition in which power speaks only through borrowed bodies, so that its proper emblem is the possessed. The *ludic Trauerspiel*, finally, names the form that binds the others together by seating the player in the intriguer's chair. *Crystalline historicity* is the name for the theory of transmission that emerges when all five are thought at once.

I.7 Plan of the work

Part One, "The Order of Blood," reconstructs Ivalice's political order: the haemocratic crisis after the Fifty Years' War and the rebellion of its discarded soldiers (Chapter 1); Delita's ascent, read through Machiavelli, Hegel, the Sengoku and Tudor paradigms of the self-made sovereign, Kant, Weber, and the Schmitt–Benjamin dispute (Chapter 2); and the vicarious bodies of Ovelia, Tietra, and Alma (Chapter 3). Part Two, "The Order of Stone," turns to political theology: the Church (Chapter 4), its suppressed scripture (Chapter 5), and the demonology of the Zodiac Stones (Chapter 6). Part Three, "The Order of the Grid," reads the game's systems as philosophy: tactics against strategy (Chapter 7), the chronopolitics of Charge Time and the arithmetic of indiscriminate death (Chapter 8), the scalar anthropology of Faith and Bravery (Chapter 9), and the crystallization of the dead (Chapter 10). Part Four, "The Order of the Record," reads the Durai Papers as historiography and situates them among the counter-histories of world literature (Chapter 11). Part Five states the synthesis as eighteen theses (Chapter 12), and the Conclusion returns to the question with which the game itself ends.



Part One

The Order of Blood

Whan Adam dalf, and Eve span, / Wo was thanne a gentilman?
When Adam delved and Eve span, who was then the gentleman?

Couplet attributed to John Ball, preaching at Blackheath, 1381

Chapter One

Haemocracy

Ivalice after the Fifty Years' War

1.1 The interregnum

Ivalice enters the narrative exhausted. The Fifty Years' War against Ordallia, with Romanda as the intervening third power, has ended without victory; the realm is fiscally ruined, plague has passed through it, and the crown, unable to pay the soldiers it raised, has discharged them. The structural analogue is the Hundred Years' War (1337–1453), whose duration the game halves, and whose aftermath in France produced the *routiers* and *écorcheurs*: disbanded companies who, deprived of employment by the Treaty of Brétigny (1360), lived by pillaging the countryside they had fought to defend. The dynastic analogue is the English minority crisis that followed. Henry VI succeeded as an infant in 1422, and the factions of his long minority hardened into the Wars of the Roses. Ivalice combines the two. King Ondoria (1998: Omdoria) dies while his heir Orinus is an infant; two dukes, Larg, the White Lion and brother of Queen Louveria, and Goltana, the Black Lion and sponsor of the princess Ovelia's claim, contest the regency; their quarrel becomes the Lion War. White and black lions for white and red roses: the heraldic transposition is exact enough to be programmatic.

Antonio Gramsci described such a condition in a note of 1930: *"La crisi consiste appunto nel fatto che il vecchio muore e il nuovo non può nascere: in questo interregno si verificano i fenomeni morbosi più svariati"* (*Quaderni del carcere*, Q3 §34). The crisis consists precisely in the fact that the old is dying and the new cannot be born; in this interregnum the most varied morbid phenomena appear. No sentence describes Ivalice more exactly, and no work makes Gramsci's metaphor more literal, for the morbid phenomena of this interregnum are demons. The Lucavi do not intrude upon a healthy body politic. They appear where the body politic cannot reproduce itself, and what they offer is precisely reproduction: a new body, Ultima's, to be grown from the blood of the old.

1.2 The three orders and their betrayal

Ivalice's ideology is tripartite. Georges Dumézil reconstructed a trifunctional ideology common to the Indo-European peoples, in which the sacred sovereignty of priest and king, the force of the warrior, and the fecundity of the producer compose a single order (*L'Idéologie tripartie des Indo-Européens*, 1958). Georges Duby traced its medieval crystallization (*Les Trois Ordres ou l'imaginaire du féodalisme*, 1978) through texts such as Adalbero of Laon's poem to King Robert (c. 1027–1031): *"Triplex ergo Dei domus est quae creditur una: / nunc orant, alii pugnant, aliique laborant."* Threefold, then, is the house of God which is believed to be one: here some pray, others fight, and others labour. The doctrine's function, as Duby showed, was to represent exploitation as reciprocity. The labourer feeds the warrior and the priest, who defend him and pray for him in return.

Ivalice maps onto the scheme with some exactness: the Glabados Church as the order that prays; the Orders of the Northern and Southern Sky, with the great houses that command them, as the order that fights; the commoners whose labour and conscription sustained fifty years of war as the order that works. The narrative consists in the successive revelation that each order has betrayed its function. The Church does not pray; it schemes, and its inner order communes with demons. The knights do not defend; they prey upon the realm they swore to protect and spend its commoners as currency. The labourers, unpaid, do not labour; they take up arms. Adalbero wrote his poem to warn a king that the orders were confounding themselves, with bishops who rode to war and rustics who presumed. *Final Fantasy Tactics* is the narrative of that confusion carried to completion: the house of God revealed to be not one but none.

1.3 Lineal blood, effusive blood

The nobility's self-understanding is haemic. Argath (1998: Algus), the scion of a disgraced house who attaches himself to the Beoulves early in the narrative, articulates the doctrine in its crudest form. Birth, he holds, assigns each person a station by heavenly decree; commoners stand to nobles as livestock to their masters; and a noble who forgets this has forgotten what he is. The claim is not merely social but ontological. It holds that nobility is a natural kind, transmitted in the blood. Foucault, in the lectures of 1976, traced the genealogy of exactly this discourse to the aristocratic historiography of Henri de Boulainvilliers, for whom the French nobility descended from conquering Franks and the commons from conquered Gauls, so that social difference was the sedimented record of a war between races. Argath's contempt is the Boulainvilliers thesis stripped of its erudition: a counter-history become a creed. The ontology fractures, moreover, inside the house of Beoulve itself. Ramza and Alma are Barbaneth's children by a different mother from their elder brothers, a woman of common birth, and when Ramza brings Zalbaag his suspicions of Dycedarg, Zalbaag answers that

Ramza is unfit for the Beoulve name, stained by his mother's common blood. The hero of the counter-history is, by the order's own measure, of impure blood.

Haemocracy requires both registers of blood. Lineal blood legitimates; effusive blood purchases. In stable times the first suffices, and the second is spent in wars at the realm's margins. But Ivalice's summit has lost its lineal blood. The king is dead; the heir is an infant whose regency must be fought over; the queen's first two sons, by the 2007 script's account, were killed in infancy at the Royal Council's behest to steer the succession; and the princess is told by the churchmen who hold her that she carries no royal blood at all (Chapter 3). Lineal blood has not merely failed; it has been made to fail. When lineal blood fails, effusive blood is summoned to supply legitimacy, and war becomes a machine for converting spilled blood into right. This is why the Lucavi are not an extraneous supernatural plot grafted onto a political one, as readers who prefer their political fiction disenchanted have sometimes complained. They are haemocracy's metaphysics made visible: beings who literally require the blood of a war in order to fashion a body for their sovereign. The Lion War is not a dynastic war interrupted by demons. It is a demonology conducted by dynastic means.

1.4 The discarded war machine

The Death Corps (1998: Corpse Brigade; in Japanese *Mukuro ryodan*, the "brigade of skeletons") is the realm's effusive blood returned to accuse it. Its members are veterans of the Fifty Years' War, raised as levies and volunteer companies, discharged unpaid at the peace, and starving. Under Wiegraf Folles they organize, first as a movement with a political grievance, then as an armed force that raids, takes a marquis for ransom, and strikes at the houses that profited from their service. The historical analogues are numerous, and they end alike. The Jacquerie of 1358 was crushed within weeks by nobles who killed thousands of peasants in reprisal. The English rising of 1381 ended with its preacher, John Ball, hanged, drawn, and quartered at St Albans in the king's presence. The routiers after Brétigny were hunted as brigands. In Japan the peasants of Shimabara rose in 1637 against a lord whose taxes outlasted famine, joined by Christians and by masterless samurai; when the shogunate's forces took Hara Castle in April 1638 they massacred those inside, men, women, and children, with estimates of the dead running from twenty to nearly forty thousand. In each case the soldiers a polity needed for war became, at the peace, a surplus it could neither employ nor admit, and the surplus was disposed of by force.

Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari supply the structural formula (*Mille plateaux*, 1980, plateau 12). The State does not possess a war machine of its own; it appropriates one, converting it into an army, and the appropriation is never complete. The Death Corps is a war machine appropriated, used, and released, and its release is the realm's undoing. The Beoulve response, to treat the Corps as brigands and exterminate them, is the State's reflex toward a

war machine it can no longer capture: it reclassifies the soldier as a criminal. The operation is as much historiographical as military. What is destroyed is not only the Corps but the memory that its members were once the realm's army.

1.5 Milleuda's question

The Corps' most lucid voice is Milleuda Folles (1998: Miluda), Wiegraf's sister, who confronts Ramza in battle and indicts the nobility in terms he cannot answer. She asks by what right the nobles treat as beasts the people who bled for them, and what distinguishes noble from commoner beyond the accident of birth, since both are human and both bleed. Her speech belongs to a lineage that includes Ball's couplet and, most closely, Shylock's "Hath not a Jew eyes?" (*The Merchant of Venice* III.i), in which a claim of common humanity is made by one whom the order excludes. The parallel extends to dramatic structure. In Shakespeare the plea for recognition does not issue in reconciliation; it licenses revenge, and the drama destroys the pleader. In *Final Fantasy Tactics* Milleuda's plea issues in no reconciliation either, but in her death at the hands of Ramza's company. The text grants the claim its truth and then kills the claimant, which is the haemocratic order's characteristic response to truth.

For Ramza the encounter is a primal scene of recognition in Hegel's sense. He recognizes in the enemy a self-consciousness equal to his own, and the recognition dislodges him from his place. It is the first fracture in the haemic ontology that the game shows from within, and it begins the dispossession that will leave him, by the end of the first chapter, a man without a house.

1.6 Zeakden: the founding corpse

Golagros, a lieutenant of the Corps, strikes at Eagrose in an attempt on Dycedarg's life. When his attempt to carry off Alma Beoulve is beaten back by Zalbaag, the Corps takes instead Tietra (1998: Teta) Heiral, Delita's sister, raised alongside the Beoulve children: the noble girl is defended, and the commoner girl is not. Dycedarg promises Delita that Tietra will not be abandoned. At Fort Zeakden, with Golagros holding a knife to her throat at the fort's gate, Zalbaag gives Argath the order to fire, and Argath shoots her with his crossbow before he shoots Golagros. Delita kills Argath; Golagros ignites the powder stored in the fort; Delita, shielded by his sister's body, survives but is presumed dead; Ramza turns his back on his house.

Every later movement of the plot proceeds from this corpse. Ramza's exodus and Delita's ascent are two responses to the same death: the one renounces the order that killed her, the other resolves to master it. René Girard's account of the founding murder (*La Violence et le sacré*, 1972; *Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde*, 1978) holds that communities are founded upon a collective killing whose victim is afterwards mythologized. Zeakden is a

founding murder of this kind, with one decisive difference: its victim is not mythologized. She is simply omitted. The official history of the Lion War, as the frame informs us, credits its hero without recording the death that made him. In Girard's vocabulary, Ramza and Delita become monstrous doubles, rivals who mirror each other ever more exactly as the crisis deepens, and so do the White and Black Lions, whose very heraldry is a chromatic inversion of the same beast. The sacrificial crisis of Ivalice is a crisis of undifferentiation, in which every faction becomes the image of its enemy.

1.7 Wiegraf: ressentiment and the pact

Wiegraf survives the first chapter and returns in the third as an agent of the Knights Templar and, at Riovanes Castle, as the host of the Lucavi Belias. His trajectory from revolutionary to demon is the game's most exact analysis of ressentiment. Nietzsche: *"Der Sklavenaufstand in der Moral beginnt damit, dass das Ressentiment selbst schöpferisch wird und Werthe gebiert"* (*Zur Genealogie der Moral* I §10). The slave revolt in morality begins when ressentiment itself becomes creative and gives birth to values. Wiegraf's ressentiment is just; it is grounded in real injury. But it does not become creative. It begets no values and founds no order; after Milleuda's death it begets only the wish to annihilate, and the Zodiac Stone answers the wish. The game thereby refines Nietzsche: ressentiment that cannot become creative becomes possessed. Max Scheler's account of ressentiment as a self-poisoning of the mind, produced where the impulse to revenge is repressed by impotence (*Das Ressentiment im Aufbau der Moralen*, 1912), describes with clinical precision the interval between Wiegraf's defeat and his pact.

Wiegraf's fall also refutes the haemic ideology from its other side. The demons accept noble and commoner alike: Belias's host is a commoner veteran, Adrammelech's the heir of the house of Beoulve. Before the stone, as before the plague, blood makes no difference.

1.8 Magna latrocinia

The difference between the Death Corps and the Lions is, finally, one of scale. Augustine's anecdote of the captured pirate (*De civitate Dei* IV.4), who tells Alexander that he does with one small ship what the king does with a great fleet, and is therefore called a robber where the king is called an emperor, is the moral of Ivalice's first chapter. Charles Tilly gave the anecdote its modern sociological form ("War Making and State Making as Organized Crime," 1985): states originate as protection rackets that monopolize the violence from which they offer protection. The Corps takes a marquis for ransom; the Lions conscript a realm. The Corps is destroyed and recorded as banditry; the Lions are recorded as history.

Haemocracy is the order in which this distinction is drawn by blood: the robber's blood is common, the emperor's royal. The achievement of *Final Fantasy Tactics* is to show that the

distinction does not survive the failure of lineal blood, and that when it fails, the robber may become king. That is the subject of the next chapter.

Chapter Two

The Agathoclean Prince

Delita Heiral and the Grammar of Ascent

2.1 The included exclusion

Delita's position at the opening is that of an included exclusion. Orphaned by plague and taken into the house of Beoulve as Ramza's companion through Barbaneth's patronage, educated at the Akademy of Gariland among noble cadets, he is granted every capacity of nobility except its name. Pierre Bourdieu's analysis of elite schooling as a rite of consecration (*La Noblesse d'État*, 1989) illuminates the arrangement. The school, on Bourdieu's account, does not merely transmit competence; it institutes a difference between the consecrated and the excluded, and transmutes social inheritance into the appearance of merit. Delita can acquire every competence the Akademy teaches and none of the consecration it confers. The game makes the Akademy's pedagogy part of its own: its tutorials are voiced by the Akademy's master, Darlavon (1998: Daravon), whose lectures a later ability converts into a soporific weapon, as though the game knew that instruction in an order's rules is also a technique of pacification.

Zeakden converts the included exclusion into knowledge. Tietra's death shows Delita that the patronage that raised him had a price list, and that he and his sister stood upon it. His subsequent career is the application of that knowledge with a thoroughness the nobility never brought to its own creed.

2.2 Machiavelli's taxonomy and the case of Agathocles

Machiavelli distinguishes new principalities by their means of acquisition: by one's own arms and *virtù* (*Il Principe*, ch. VI, the chapter of Moses, Cyrus, Romulus, and Theseus); by the arms of others and by fortune (ch. VII, the chapter of Cesare Borgia); and by crime (ch. VIII, the chapter of Agathocles of Syracuse and Oliverotto da Fermo). Delita traverses all three. He rises first by fortune and by the arms of others, through the Church's patronage and Goltana's army. He consolidates by crime: the abduction of Ovelia at Orbonne; the summary execution of Chancellor Glevanne (1998: Gelwan) on a prisoner's accusation, followed by the counsel that sent Goltana's army against Lesalia and began the War of the Lions; and, at Fort

Besselat, the assassination of Goltana on the Church's commission, pinned on Count Orlandeau and sealed by the execution of a decoy in Orlandeau's place, before Delita turns upon the Church itself. And at the end he holds the realm by something resembling *virtù* in its strict sense, the capacity to master fortune through foresight.

Agathocles, the potter's son who became tyrant of Syracuse, is the paradigm Delita most closely resembles, and Machiavelli's judgement on him is the judgement the game passes on its hero: *"Non si può ancora chiamare virtù ammazzare li sua cittadini, tradire li amici, essere sanza fede, sanza pietà, sanza religione; li quali modi possono fare acquistare imperio, ma non gloria."* Nor can it be called virtue to kill one's fellow citizens, to betray one's friends, to be without faith, without mercy, without religion; by such means one may acquire empire, but not glory.

The distinction between *imperio* and *gloria* is, for Machiavelli, historiographical. Glory is what posterity grants, and posterity is written by historians; the author of the *Istorie fiorentine* knew that the judge of glory is the chronicler. The frame of *Final Fantasy Tactics* stages exactly this. Delita obtains *imperio*; the official history grants him *gloria*; the Durai Papers revoke it. The game thereby relocates Machiavelli's distinction from the moral sphere to the archival. Glory is not a quality of deeds but a function of records, and because it can be counterfeited it can also be revoked. Machiavelli's ambivalence survives the transposition: he concedes Agathocles a *virtù d'animo* in the facing of dangers that he refuses to call glorious, and the game concedes Delita a courage and lucidity that it refuses to call good.

2.3 Lord and bondsman

Hegel's account of lordship and bondage (*Phänomenologie des Geistes*, 1807, "Herrschaft und Knechtschaft") describes two self-consciousnesses locked in a struggle for recognition. The one who risks life becomes lord; the one who fears death becomes bondsman. Yet the lord's victory is hollow, since the recognition he receives comes from a consciousness he has made dependent and is therefore worthless to him, while the bondsman, through fear, service, and labour upon the object (*Furcht*, *Dienst*, *Arbeit*), comes to a self-consciousness the lord never attains. Alexandre Kojève made the dialectic the motor of history (*Introduction à la lecture de Hegel*, 1947): the slave, by labour, makes history, while the master is an existential impasse.

Delita is the bondsman who understands the dialectic and refuses its conclusion. He does not seek freedom through labour; he seeks lordship, and in obtaining it he obtains the lord's impasse. The recognition he receives comes from dependents: courtiers, a queen whose blood is in doubt, an official chronicle. At the end, master of everything, he is recognized by no one whose recognition he values. Ramza is gone, Tietra is dead, and Ovelia's last act is a refusal. Kojève's post-historical man, having nothing left to negate, subsides into contentment or animality; Delita subsides into a question. The ending is a parable of the end of history in Ko-

jève's sense, staged five years after Francis Fukuyama's popularization of the thesis (*The End of History and the Last Man*, 1992): the struggle for recognition terminates in a victory that delivers none.

2.4 Gekokujō

Japanese history supplies a native grammar for this ascent: *gekokujō*, "the low overcoming the high," the term that names the Sengoku age's overturning of status. Its exemplary figure is Toyotomi Hideyoshi, son of a peasant foot-soldier, who rose through service to Oda Nobunaga to unify the country. Barred as a commoner from the shogunate, he obtained the regency in 1585 by adoption into the Konoe, a house of Fujiwara descent: a commoner grafted onto lineal blood by legal fiction. Having risen by *gekokujō*, Hideyoshi closed the ladder behind him. The sword-hunt edict of 1588 disarmed the peasantry, and the edict of 1591 fixed the boundaries between warrior, peasant, and townsman, so that no one could repeat his ascent.

Delita's marriage to Ovelia is his adoption into the Konoe. The irony the game adds is that the blood onto which he grafts himself is itself in doubt. The Church's own agents have told Ovelia that she is a counterfeit, so that Delita's legitimacy rests on testimony that no one in Ivalice can verify (Chapter 3). Hideyoshi's sealing of the status order also prompts the counterfactual the game leaves unspoken: what must Delita's kingdom do to prevent another Delita? The erasure of Ramza from the official record is part of the answer. A regime that rose by exposing the arbitrariness of blood must conceal the arbitrariness of its own rise.

2.5 The Tudor paradigm

The European analogue is Henry VII. The victor of Bosworth (1485) claimed the crown through his mother's Beaufort line and descended on his father's side from Owen Tudor, a Welsh squire of the royal household who had married the widow of Henry V: a lineage of doubtful royal blood. He legitimated his conquest by marrying Elizabeth of York (1486), uniting the warring houses under the Tudor rose, as Delita, by marrying Ovelia, unites the claims over which the Lions fought. The dynasty fostered a historiography, from Polydore Vergil's *Anglica Historia* and Thomas More's *History of King Richard III* to its theatrical apex in Shakespeare's histories, that E. M. W. Tillyard would later call the Tudor myth (*Shakespeare's History Plays*, 1944): a providential narrative in which the usurper's victory restores the divine order and the defeated king becomes a monster. The official history of Delita is a Tudor myth. The Durai Papers are its Ricardian revision (Chapter 11).

2.6 Edmund and Griffith

Literature offers two close kinsmen. The first is Edmund in *King Lear*, the illegitimate son who takes Nature for his goddess and repudiates "the plague of custom" (I.ii) that ranks him beneath his legitimate brother. Delita's critique of status is Edmund's naturalism, but where Edmund's motive is appetite, Delita's is, at least in its origin, love: for Tietra, and later, perhaps, for Ovelia. Dying, Edmund resolves to do some good in despite of his own nature and tries to countermand the order for Cordelia's death, too late (V.iii). Delita's last scene, flowers carried to the woman he has used, is the same gesture, equally belated.

The second is Griffith in Miura Kentarō's *Berserk*: a commoner whose dream of a kingdom of his own organizes everyone around him; who, broken, uses a stone relic, the Behelit, to offer his comrades of the Band of the Hawk as a sacrifice to the God Hand, whose servants slaughter them; who, reborn as the demon Femto, rapes Casca, the comrade who loved him, while Guts is held down and made to watch; and who afterwards marries a princess and rules. The structural parallel with Delita is close enough to make the difference decisive. Delita never takes a stone. Every other figure in Ivalice who pursues power by extraordinary means (Wiegraf, Delacroix, Elmdor, Dycedarg, Folmarv) makes the Lucavi pact. Delita alone achieves by human means what they pursue by demonic ones, and he outlives them all. This is the game's darkest proposition: the demon is optional. Politics does not need the Lucavi; the Lucavi are an allegory of what politics does without them. The two works agree on one further point. Miura consummates the sovereign's apotheosis in sexual violence against the woman nearest him; Matsuno closes the sovereign's reign with the killing of the woman he married. In both, the ascent is completed upon a woman's body, which is the subject of Chapter 3.

2.7 The Kingdom of Means

Kant's formula of humanity reads: *"Handle so, daß du die Menschheit, sowohl in deiner Person, als in der Person eines jeden andern, jederzeit zugleich als Zweck, niemals bloß als Mittel brauchest"* (*Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*, 1785, AA 4:429). So act that you use humanity, in your own person as in the person of every other, always at the same time as an end, never merely as a means. The Kingdom of Ends is the systematic union of rational beings under such laws.

Delita's professed end, a world in which no one will be used as Tietra was used, is precisely a Kingdom of Ends. His means are universal instrumentalization: Ramza, Ovelia, Goltana, Orlandeau, the Church. The final scene closes the circle. Ovelia, the person in whose name he acted, accuses him of meaning to use her as he has used everyone else, and the accusation is unanswerable because the logic of means is total and cannot exempt its own end. Delita's realm is the Kingdom of Ends inverted into a Kingdom of Means, in which

every end becomes the means to the next. The exchange of blades in the ruined chapel at Zeltennia is the formula of humanity taking its revenge.

2.8 Dirty hands and diabolical powers

Max Weber distinguished the ethic of conviction from the ethic of responsibility (*Politik als Beruf*, 1919) and warned that whoever engages in politics, whose decisive means is violence, *"läßt sich mit den diabolischen Mächten ein, die in jeder Gewaltsamkeit lauern"*: enters into dealings with the diabolical powers that lurk in all violence. Delita is the responsible politician par excellence. He weighs consequences, accepts dirty hands (the problem named by Sartre's *Les Mains sales*, 1948, and analysed by Michael Walzer in 1973), and does not pretend otherwise. *Final Fantasy Tactics* literalizes Weber's diabolical powers as the Lucavi and then withholds them from its most political figure, because he has no need of them. The pact he makes is with violence itself.

2.9 From decision to melancholy

Carl Schmitt made the decision on the exception the mark of sovereignty (*Politische Theologie*, 1922), and the distinction between friend and enemy the criterion of the political (*Der Begriff des Politischen*, 1932). The theory's own history belongs to its meaning. Schmitt joined the National Socialist party on 1 May 1933 and within days applauded the burning of books by Jewish authors; on 1 August 1934 he published "Der Führer schützt das Recht," defending as the highest form of law the killings of 30 June to 2 July 1934, in which Hitler had Ernst Röhm and other leaders of the SA, together with political opponents, murdered without trial. Among the dead was Kurt von Schleicher, the general and former chancellor whom Schmitt had advised. The decisionist theory of sovereignty was thus offered, by its author, as the legal justification of murders ordered by a ruler against his own followers and his former patrons. Delita's career is a sequence of exceptional decisions of exactly this kind: the execution of Chancellor Glevanne; the killing of Goltana, whom he served; the framing of Orlandeau; the betrayal of the Church that raised him. Friend and enemy are redrawn whenever advantage shifts, and each redrawing is sealed with a death.

But the epilogue stages Benjamin's answer to Schmitt. In the *Trauerspiel* book (1928), the baroque sovereign is not the one who decides but the one who cannot; overwhelmed by melancholy, his figure splits in two: *"Tyrann und Märtyrer sind im Barock die Janushäupter des Gekrönten."* Tyrant and martyr are, in the baroque, the Janus-heads of the crowned one. In the final scene Delita is both at once, in a single instant: tyrant, who kills his queen; martyr, stabbed by the woman he loves. The decider ends in the Saturnine posture of the melancholy prince, alone in a ruined chapel beside the flowers he brought her, addressing a question to an absent friend. Giorgio Agamben has reconstructed the exchange between Schmitt and Ben-

jamin as an esoteric dossier on sovereignty and the exception (*Stato di eccezione*, 2003); Delita's final scene is its dramatization, the passage from Schmitt's sovereign to Benjamin's within one life.

2.10 "What did I get?"

The question Delita addresses to the absent Ramza is the question of yield: what does history pay? Ecclesiastes asks it in the form the King James translators gave it ("What profit hath a man of all his labour which he taketh under the sun?", 1:3). The *Heike* answers it: おごれる人も久しからず、ただ春の夜の夢のごとし, the proud do not endure; they are only a dream on a spring night. Delita is not the villain of *Final Fantasy Tactics*. He is its theorist in action, the figure of political modernity itself: the self-made sovereign whose success voids the end it served. His question is the game's question, and it is put to the player as well, who has also won.

Chapter Three

Vicarious Bodies

Ovelia, Tietra, Alma

3.1 The grammar of substitution

Ivalice's political grammar is substitution. An inventory is instructive. The princess Ovelia is told by the churchmen who hold her that she is a stand-in for a royal child who died, and the game never confirms or refutes it. Tietra is seized when the attempt on Alma fails. Alma is chosen as the vessel in which Ultima, under the name of Saint Ajora, is to be reborn. The hosts of the Lucavi are bodies occupied by other wills. Rapha and Marach Galthena are carried off from their razed village by a grand duke and raised to kill in his name. Delita, presumed dead at Zeakden, returns under the colours of another faction. Count Orlandeau, reported executed for a murder Delita committed, survives because another man is executed in his place. And Ramza himself is replaced in the official record by the man who became king. The plot is a system of stand-ins, and its political theory follows from it: sovereignty in Ivalice is vicarious. Power never speaks in its own body; it speaks through borrowed ones.

3.2 The two bodies of a counterfeit princess

Ernst Kantorowicz reconstructed the Tudor jurists' doctrine that the king has two bodies (*The King's Two Bodies*, 1957): a body natural, mortal and fallible, and a body politic, immortal and incorporating the realm, which passes to the successor at the moment of death, so that the king never dies. Ovelia's case exposes the fiction's hinge. Officially she is the trueborn daughter of King Denamda IV, adopted by her half-brother the king at the Royal Council's suggestion, so as to leave Queen Louveria as little power as possible. The token that certified her birth, kept by the elder of Orbonne, was the Virgo auracite: the stone in which Ultima waits. And while she is their prisoner, Folmarv and Cardinal Delacroix, the Church's agents and both of them Lucavi hosts, tell her that the real Ovelia died in infancy and that she is a substitute. If they speak truly, her two bodies belong to two persons, the political body of a dead princess worn by an anonymous girl, and she is the double not of herself but of a corpse. If they lie, the lie does its work as well as the truth would, for a princess unsure of her own

blood is easier to use. Either way the two bodies have come apart, and what binds them is testimony she cannot check.

The Japanese name for this condition is *kagemusha*, the "shadow warrior" or body double of a lord. In Kurosawa Akira's *Kagemusha* (1980), a condemned thief is spared to impersonate the warlord Takeda Shingen after his death; the clan's survival depends on the illusion; exposed, he is expelled, and he dies following the clan's army into the slaughter at Nagashino. The film's argument is that the political body requires the annihilation of the natural person who bears it: the double may live only as another. Ovelia's life obeys the same law. Raised in the cloister at Orbonne and taken up by factions, she is told of her substitution at the moment of her greatest political value, by captors who profit from her doubt, and the telling does not free her; true or false, it tells her what she is for.

The English history on which the game draws knew the phenomenon from the other side, in the pretenders of the Wars of the Roses. Lambert Simnel, crowned in Dublin in 1487 as Edward of Warwick, was spared after the battle of Stoke and set to work in the royal kitchens. Perkin Warbeck, who claimed to be Richard of Shrewsbury, the younger of the princes in the Tower, was hanged at Tyburn in 1499. Both were manufactured by factions that needed a body for a claim. Ovelia is either a pretender who never pretended or a true princess taught to believe she is one, and the text will not say which.

Hobbes gives the formal description in his chapter on persons, authors, and things personated (*Leviathan*, 1651, ch. XVI): "A Person, is he, whose words or actions are considered, either as his own, or as representing the words or actions of an other man." Where the words are another's, the person is feigned or artificial; the one who acts is the actor, and the one who owns the action is the author. Ovelia is an actor whose authors are, successively, the Church, Goltana, and Delita. Her tragedy is that no one, the realm included, regards her words as her own until she speaks with a knife.

3.3 Tietra and Alma: the substitution of girls

The game opens and closes upon the substitution of girls' bodies. Tietra is seized in Alma's place and killed because a commoner's life weighs nothing in the noble calculus. Alma is seized at the end because her body is wanted as the vessel for a resurrection. Between these two seizures stretches the whole plot, and the symmetry tells us how to read Ramza's quest. Zeakden established the rule that a commoner girl may die in place of a noble one. The Lucavi extend it: a noble girl may be emptied so that a god may live in her. Ramza's final campaign, through the necropolis beneath Mullonde to the Airship Graveyard, is a war against substitution as such, the attempt to restore one girl to herself in expiation of the girl who could not be restored.

The theological stakes are precise. In Christian devotion the Virgin is the vessel of the incarnate God, invoked in the Litany of Loreto as *vas spirituale, vas honorabile, vas insigne devotionis*, and her consent (*fiat mihi*, Luke 1:38) is the hinge of the Incarnation. Alma, chosen under the sign of Virgo, is a vessel without consent; the resurrection the Lucavi intend is an annunciation without a *fiat*. The demonology of *Final Fantasy Tactics* parodies exactly the doctrine in which a woman's consent is theologically decisive, and in doing so it identifies the violence of vicarious sovereignty with the abolition of consent.

3.4 The traffic in women

Claude Lévi-Strauss's account of exogamy as an exchange of women among men that constitutes alliance (*Les Structures élémentaires de la parenté*, 1949), and Gayle Rubin's feminist rereading of it as "The Traffic in Women" (1975), name the circuit Ovelia travels. Larg's faction wants her eliminated; Goltana's wants her as figurehead; the Church wants her as instrument; Delita wants her as wife and crown. In every transaction she is the medium of an alliance between men. The one woman in the narrative who trades in men rather than being traded is Queen Louveria, and script and history alike demonize her. The retranslation's "Louveria" (French *louve*, she-wolf) cannot but recall the "she-wolf of France" whom York curses in *3 Henry VI* (I.iv): Margaret of Anjou, the queen who fought for her son's claim as Louveria fights for Orinus's.

The most extreme instrumentalization in the game involves no exchange at all. Rapha Galthena and her brother Marach (1998: Rafa and Malak) were born into a village whose hereditary arts, the Sky Mantra and the Nether Mantra, Grand Duke Gerrith Barrington of Riovanes (1998: Barinten) coveted. When the village's leaders refused to give up the children, Barrington had the village razed and carried them off. He raised them as instruments: Marach as one of his assassins, believing himself rescued and indebted; Rapha as a captive whom Barrington raped, without her brother's knowledge. When she confronts him on the roof of Riovanes Castle, he admits it. Hers is vicarious sovereignty at its most intimate: a lord who uses a girl's body twice over, as a weapon against others and as an object of his own predation. Ovelia is passed between men as the medium of alliance; Rapha is held by one man as property. And Rapha's case alone shows the instrumentalized body striking back and surviving. She escapes him, accuses him, and lives to join Ramza's company with the brother she brings back from the brink of death.

Agrias Oaks, the Holy Knight of Ovelia's guard, offers the chivalric counter-model. Johan Huizinga argued that late-medieval chivalry was a beautiful dream laid over a brutal world (*Herfsttij der Middeleeuwen*, 1919), and Agrias is that dream in armour. Her loyalty, sworn to a royal person, might seem to presuppose a royal blood that Ovelia's captors call into question. The text never suggests, however, that her fidelity depends on blood; it is directed to

Ovelia herself. In that indifference the game locates the one bond in Ivalice that does not require the haemic order: loyalty to a person rather than to a lineage. Agrias's chivalry is purified by the doubt cast on its official object. She serves the girl, whatever the truth about the princess, and her parting gift, a dagger for Ovelia's protection, becomes the instrument of the game's last act.

3.5 Ovelia's knife

Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question, whether the subaltern can speak (1988), was posed through the case of a young woman whose suicide, intended as a message, was misread by those who survived her. Ovelia's only unscripted act is to stab Delita with the dagger Agrias gave her, and its meaning is overwritten at once: by his counter-stroke, by the official history that records nothing of the scene, and by the player's own uncertainty as to what exactly has happened in that ruined chapel. Her accusation, that he will use her as he has used everyone, is the most lucid political analysis spoken in the game, and it is spoken by the game's most instrumentalized figure. That is the subaltern's speech under vicarious sovereignty: true, unheard, and answered with a blade. The game's one counter-instance is Rapha's accusation at Riovanes, which is heard: Barrington admits his crime, and her brother turns on him at the cost of a bullet. Even there, recognition arrives only with a weapon.

Two older figures frame the act. Judith beheads Holofernes in his tent with his own sword and delivers her people (Judith 13), and her deed passed into an iconography of righteous female violence from Caravaggio to Artemisia Gentileschi. Ovelia's knife, raised against her husband, delivers no one and is answered in kind. Antigone, in Judith Butler's reading (*Antigone's Claim*, 2000), speaks for a kinship the state cannot recognize. Ovelia speaks for a self the state never recognized at all, whether a princess taught to doubt her blood or an anonymous girl beneath the title. The game does not say which, and her act is the same in either case.

3.6 The possessed as emblem

The Lucavi are vicarity hypostatized: spirits that exist only by occupying borrowed bodies. They are the theological truth of a political order in which every claim needs a body not its own. Hobbes's sovereign is an artificial person, a body politic animated by the wills it represents; the Lucavi are artificial persons in reverse, wills in search of natural bodies to animate. Seen thus, the possessed host, not the crowned king, is the true emblem of Ivalician sovereignty.

The game's least remarked mechanical fact now becomes significant. The player's generic recruits are named by a random generator, assigned birthdays by chance, and sent into battle as interchangeable bodies; when they fall, others are hired at the nearest town. The player's

sovereignty over the grid is vicarious sovereignty in its purest form, and the game makes the player practise, battle after battle, the economy its narrative condemns. What it does with those bodies when they die is the subject of Chapter 10.



PART TWO

The Order of Stone

"...the Papacy, is no other, than the Ghost of the deceased Romane Empire, sitting crowned upon the grave thereof."

Thomas Hobbes, *Leviathan*, 1651, ch. XLVII

Chapter Four

The Ghost of the Deceased Empire

The Glabados Church

4.1 A church upon a grave

The Glabados Church is founded upon the memory of Saint Ajora and governs from its holy city of Mullonde. Beneath the cathedral lies the Necrohol of Mullonde (1998: Murond Death City), a city of the dead through which Ramza descends in the final chapter; beyond it lie the Lost Sacred Precincts and, at the last, the Airship Graveyard, the wreckage of an older and more technically accomplished civilization. The Church's own legend explains the topography. In Ajora's day Mullonde was the centre of the Pharist faith under the Holy Ydoran Empire, and at the moment of his execution, the legend says, the city sank into the sea. The holy see therefore sits, quite literally, crowned upon the grave of the order that killed its founder, and the descent from its cathedral leads, stratum by stratum, into the ruins on which it stands. Even the place of execution carries a scriptural echo. By the Church's account Ajora died on the gallows of Golgollada (1998: Golgorand), a name that cannot fail to recall Golgotha, "a place of a skull" (Matthew 27:33); the map of Ivalice keeps the Passion's topography even where the Church has rewritten its story.

Hobbes devoted the fourth part of *Leviathan* to "the Kingdome of Darknesse," which he defined (ch. XLIV) as "a Confederacy of Deceivers, that to obtain dominion over men in this present world, endeavour by dark, and erroneous Doctrines, to extinguish in them the Light, both of Nature, and of the Gospell." In the following chapter, "Of Daemonology," he treated belief in demons as a relic of pagan error preserved by the clergy because it served their power. *Final Fantasy Tactics* accepts the first proposition and inverts the second. The Church is a confederacy of deceivers seeking dominion in this present world; but its demons are no relic of error. They are real, and the Church keeps them.

4.2 Tertius gaudens

Schmitt's thesis in *Politische Theologie* (1922) is that the significant concepts of the modern theory of the state are secularized theological concepts. *Final Fantasy Tactics* reverses the vector. Its theology is not the hidden source of its politics; its theology is politics in vestments.

The Church's design, as the narrative discloses it, is to let the nobility exhaust itself in the Lion War and then to inherit the realm. It places instruments in both camps (Delita among them), sustains the conflict, and waits.

Georg Simmel's figure of the *tertius gaudens*, the third who rejoices, the party that profits from the conflict of two others (*Soziologie*, 1908), is the exact sociological description: the first order exploiting the war between the two halves of the second. Simmel also observed the instability of the third's position, which lasts only so long as the combatants fail to perceive its profit. In Ivalice the Church is undone not by the Lions but by its own interior. Folmarv, Grand Master of the Templars and host of a Lucavi, kills the High Confessor Funebris; Delita, the Church's instrument, turns upon his patrons. The third who rejoices is destroyed by its own third.

4.3 Miracle, mystery, and authority

In the legend Ivan Karamazov recites to his brother (*The Brothers Karamazov*, 1880, Book V, ch. 5), the Grand Inquisitor tells the returned Christ that the Church has corrected his work by taking up the three powers he refused in the wilderness, "miracle, mystery and authority," and confesses that the Church has long laboured not with Christ but with the tempter. The Glabados Church administers Ajora's legend as the Inquisitor administers Christ's. It supplies the miracle (the stones and the legend of the Zodiac Braves), the mystery (a sacred history no layman may examine), and the authority (Inquisition and Templars). And its inner order is literally with the tempter, for the Templars commune with the Lucavi. The game takes Ivan's parable and removes its "as if": the Inquisitor's secret becomes a fact of the plot.

The difference is as instructive as the likeness. Dostoevsky's Inquisitor claims to act out of love for human weakness, sparing a frail humanity the burden of freedom; the motive of Funebris is institutional power, and that of the Templars the demons' resurrection. *Final Fantasy Tactics* is less generous to its inquisitors than Dostoevsky, and in that respect more Hobbesian. It discerns in the clerical will to power not a tragic love but a confederacy.

4.4 The Templars and the truth of slander

The historical Knights Templar were arrested throughout France on 13 October 1307 at the command of Philip IV and charged with heresy, idolatry (the veneration of a head the records call Baphomet), and sacrilegious rites of initiation. Many of the brothers confessed under torture applied by royal officers and inquisitors, and many later retracted. By early May 1310 nearly six hundred had come forward to defend the order before a papal commission. The defence was broken by fire. Philippe de Marigny, archbishop of Sens, a royal nominee and brother of the king's chief minister, condemned fifty-four of those who had retracted as relapsed heretics, and on 12 May 1310 they were burned in a field outside Paris. Clement V

suppressed the order in 1312, and its last Grand Master, Jacques de Molay, was burned in Paris in 1314 after withdrawing his own confession. Modern historians, notably Malcolm Barber (*The Trial of the Templars*, 1978), have concluded that the charges were largely fabricated by a crown that coveted the order's wealth, and proved by confessions that torture had produced. The Church's military order in *Final Fantasy Tactics* bears the Japanese name *shinden kishidan*, "temple knights," and the retranslation renders it "Knights Templar"; in the game the Templars really are what Philip's propaganda alleged, an order consorting with demons under a veil of sanctity.

The irony is reflexive and of a high order. The game's sympathies lie with a man the Church falsely brands a heretic, yet it stages, in the Templars, a charge of heresy that is true. It thereby refuses the comfortable conclusion that accusations of heresy are always false. Accusation is a genre; its truth must be established case by case, and the instrument for establishing it is the archive. The game's own method, the counter-record set against the record, is the only safeguard it offers, and it offers that safeguard without guarantees.

4.5 Armed religion: Hiei, the Ikkō leagues, and 1995

Japanese history knows the armed church intimately. The monastery of Enryaku-ji on Mount Hiei maintained warrior monks who for centuries pressed the court with arms, until Oda Nobunaga burned the mountain in 1571 and slaughtered its inhabitants, monks and lay people alike. The Ikkō leagues, confederations of True Pure Land believers drawn from the peasantry, the lesser warriors, and the clergy, governed Kaga province from 1488 until 1580, a domain contemporaries described as a province held by the peasants; the fortress-temple of Ishiyama Hongan-ji withstood Nobunaga for a decade (1570–1580). The Christian century ended at Shimabara, where in April 1638 the shogunate's forces took Hara Castle and massacred those inside, men, women, and children, with estimates of the dead running from twenty to nearly forty thousand, after which the Tokugawa regime drove Christianity underground through compulsory registration at Buddhist temples and the periodic trampling of sacred images. A Japanese player of 1997 needed no European analogue to recognize a church with an army, a treasury, and territorial ambitions, or a state that answered such a church with massacre. The native history was explicit.

The recent memory was darker. Aum Shinrikyō, whose sarin attack on the Tokyo subway on 20 March 1995, ordered by its leader Asahara Shōkō, killed thirteen people and injured more than 5,800 by the count of Japan's Ministry of Justice, had organized itself as a shadow state with ministries of its own, pursued chemical and biological weapons, and preached an apocalypse it sought to hasten. No claim of influence is made here. The point is that the game's first audience had just witnessed a religious organization pursuing the end of the world through violence and secrecy, and that the Templars of *Final Fantasy Tactics*, who seek

to accomplish a resurrection through mass bloodshed, entered a culture in which that figure was not fantastic.

4.6 Charisma routinized, apparatus doubled

Weber described how the charisma of a founder becomes, after his death, an everyday institution, through the routinization of charisma (*Veralltäglichung des Charisma*, in *Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*, 1922). Ajora's charisma has been routinized into offices, relics, and doctrines, and the institution depends upon a past it must curate and, when necessary, falsify. Louis Althusser's distinction between ideological and repressive state apparatuses (1970) names the Church's double nature. It is an ideological apparatus, with its doctrine, preaching, and sacraments, that also possesses a repressive apparatus of its own in the Templars and the Inquisition. It is not, therefore, an apparatus of the State but a state within the state, equipped with both apparatuses and competing with the crown for the monopoly of legitimate violence that Weber made the definition of statehood.

4.7 The manufacture of heresy

Ramza becomes a heretic by declaration, pronounced at the gates of Lesalia by the inquisitor Zalmour (1998: Zalmo). The Church brands him so when he obstructs its designs, and heresy, in the game as in history, is a juridical category produced by the institution that requires it. The archetype is Joan of Arc, condemned as a relapsed heretic by an ecclesiastical court presided over by Pierre Cauchon, bishop of Beauvais and partisan of the English occupation, burned at Rouen in 1431, rehabilitated by a nullification trial in 1456, and canonized in 1920. Her history is the history of a heresy charge reversed by an archive. The Durai Papers aspire to a nullification trial for Ramza.

Foucault's analysis of the spectacle of the scaffold (*Surveiller et punir*, 1975), in which the body of the condemned is the surface on which sovereignty inscribes its power, illuminates the fate of Orran Durai. The Church cannot burn Ramza, who has vanished, so it burns his historian, and the punishment falls upon the writing. The lineage is long. Jan Hus was condemned by the Council of Constance and burned there in 1415, despite the emperor's safe-conduct. William Tyndale, translator of the Bible into English, was condemned for heresy and strangled and burned at Vilvoorde in 1536. Giordano Bruno was condemned by the Roman Inquisition and burned in Rome in 1600. In each case the institution killed the bearer of a text that threatened its monopoly of interpretation. In the vocabulary this dissertation proposes, the petrific regime burns those who would crystallize.

4.8 Engineered myth: *Dune* and the ecclesial cycle

Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965) supplies the speculative tradition's fullest account of religion as an engineered instrument. The Bene Gesserit's Missionaria Protectiva seeds prophecies among subject peoples so that the sisterhood's agents may one day exploit them; Paul Atreides steps into a messianic legend planted generations before his birth, and the sequels follow the holy war he unleashes, which kills billions. Herbert described the series in later years as a warning against charismatic leaders. The Glabados Church is a Missionaria Protectiva that has forgotten it is one. Its legends of Ajora and the Zodiac Braves were constructed for use, and the institution now believes them, or administers them as though it did. Delita stands to the Church as Paul stands to the Bene Gesserit: the beneficiary of a myth-making apparatus he did not build, who turns its product against its makers.

Within Square's own corpus, *Final Fantasy Tactics* opens a cycle of ecclesial critique. *Xenogears* (1998) gives its world a church, Ethos, that monopolizes the excavated technology of a lost age on behalf of a hidden power. *Final Fantasy X* (2001) makes the teachings of Yevon the instrument that perpetuates the cycle of death they claim to redeem. *Final Fantasy XII* (2006), Matsuno's return to Ivalice, gives the steering of history to gods, the Occuria, who bend human affairs through the stones they bestow, until an ambitious prince seeks to take history back into human hands. Outside Square, Atlus's *Shin Megami Tensei* (1992) had already set a messianic church of Law against the forces of Chaos in a ruined Tokyo and left the player to judge both. The Japanese role-playing game of the 1990s thus developed a sustained critique of religious institutions as managers of history, and *Final Fantasy Tactics* is its most historiographically self-conscious instance.

Chapter Five

The Gospel of the Traitor

The Germonik Scriptures

5.1 The document

The Germonik Scriptures come to Ramza from Simon, elder of Orbonne Monastery and once an inquisitor of the Church, who deciphered them line by line in the monastery's underground library and passes them to Ramza with his last breath. The Church's legend, which Ramza recalls before he reads, is a Passion in all but name. Ajora was born in Bervenia some twelve hundred years before, in an age when airships still flew; as an infant he foretold a plague and saved the families who heeded him; he gathered the twelve Zodiac Stones and, with the Zodiac Braves, defeated a demon summoned by the lord of Limberry; the Holy Ydoran Empire, urged on by the priests of the reigning Pharist faith, hunted him down; his thirteenth disciple, Germonik, betrayed him for coin; he was executed on the gallows of Golgollada at the age of twenty; and Mullonde, centre of the Pharist faith, sank into the sea beneath a rain of blood.

The Scriptures tell another story. Their Ajora is mortal: a revolutionary pursuing his own ends, whose promise of fair treatment drew the slaves and the destitute of the empire, and who was in truth a spy and saboteur sent into the Holy Ydoran Empire by a rival state, his faith a means of bringing the empire down from within. Germonik did hand him over, but not for coin: the empire had employed him to gather the evidence that would convict Ajora as a spy. Simon's marginal notes complete the indictment. After Ajora's death the Church, which had ridden his influence to power, had to erase his humanity from the record, and it borrowed the continent's legend of the Zodiac Braves to make him the vanquisher of a demon that, Simon writes, never existed. The document does not dispute a doctrine; it dissolves a title. What it threatens is not the Church's theology but the Church's right to exist as the custodian of a sacred past.

5.2 The Judas traditions

The Judas of the canonical gospels betrays his master for thirty pieces of silver (Matthew 26:14–16) and dies in despair (Matthew 27:3–5) or bursts asunder (Acts 1:18). But a

counter-tradition is as old as the Church's polemic against its heretics. Irenaeus of Lyon (*Adversus haereses* I.31.1, c. 180) reports that a sect later called the Cainites possessed a gospel of Judas, in which Judas alone among the disciples knew the truth and so accomplished the *proditionis mysterium*, the mystery of the betrayal. The text was known only through its enemy's report until a Coptic manuscript, the Codex Tchacos, surfaced and was published in 2006. *Final Fantasy Tactics*, nearly a decade earlier, imagined the genre's return: a betrayer's gospel, preserved against the institution, that turns the founding narrative inside out.

Twentieth-century literature returned to Judas repeatedly. In Borges's "Tres versiones de Judas" (1944), the invented Swedish theologian Nils Runeberg proposes successively that Judas's betrayal was the necessary reflection on earth of the Incarnation, that it was an act of supreme asceticism in which Judas renounced even virtue, and finally that God became not Jesus but Judas. Nikos Kazantzakis's *The Last Temptation of Christ* (1955) makes Judas the strongest of the disciples, charged by Jesus himself with the betrayal. Endō Shūsaku's *Chinmoku* (*Silence*, 1966), set in the Tokugawa shogunate's persecution of Japan's Christians, in which missionaries and converts were tortured until they renounced their faith, gives the betrayer a Japanese face in Kichijirō, who apostatizes again and again, betrays the priest Rodrigues, and returns to beg for confession, and whom the novel at last declines to condemn, because weakness too may be a form of faith. José Saramago's *O Evangelho segundo Jesus Cristo* (1991), in which God uses Jesus as the instrument of an expanding dominion, was struck in 1992 from Portugal's candidates for the European Literary Prize by António Sousa Lara, under-secretary of state for culture, who judged it offensive to Catholics; Saramago left for Lanzarote in protest. The suppression enacted its own subject.

Germonik belongs to this lineage, with a decisive difference. His own text does not deny that he handed Ajora over; it denies the meaning the Church gave the act. In the Church's legend he is Judas, tempted by coin. In his Scriptures he is the empire's informant, and the man he betrayed was no messiah but the agent of another state. The betrayer becomes the only witness to what the institution erased, and his testimony passes from the empire's informant to the Church's former inquisitor to the Church's heretic, each a traitor to the institution that employed him. The game thereby formulates a principle that governs the whole of its historiography: the traitor is the only witness. Counter-history begins in an act of disloyalty to the institution that controls the record, and every history written against the victors must at some point commit Germonik's treason.

5.3 The theme of the traitor and the hero

Borges's "Tema del traidor y del héroe" (1944) is the game's most exact literary analogue. Its narrator imagines a historian, Ryan, investigating the assassination in 1824 of his great-grandfather Fergus Kilpatrick, hero of an Irish conspiracy. Ryan discovers that Kilpatrick was the

traitor who had betrayed the conspiracy; that his fellow conspirators, unable to expose a hero without destroying their cause, condemned him and staged his execution as a public assassination, scripted in part from Shakespeare's *Julius Caesar* and *Macbeth*, so that his death would inflame the nation; and that the drama was so built that a later investigator might uncover it. Ryan, having uncovered it, keeps silent and publishes a book in the hero's glory. That too, Borges suggests, had perhaps been foreseen.

Final Fantasy Tactics reads as a reply to Borges, and it even contains a Ryan of its own. Simon, the former inquisitor who deciphered the Scriptures, knew the truth for years and kept silent. His notes give two reasons. Publication would have brought a charge of heresy and the stake; but the true reason, he confesses, was his library, which he could not bear to lose, so that his curiosity outweighed his will to do what was right. Borges's Ryan keeps silent to protect a cause; Simon keeps silent to protect his books. Against both stands the frame. The Church's Ajora is a Kilpatrick, a political figure whose death was narrated so as to generate a cult. Delita is Kilpatrick inverted, a hero in the official record whose truth the counter-archive preserves. And Alazlam Durai is a Ryan who refuses Ryan's silence. Where Borges's historian chooses the consoling fiction and thereby becomes a character in the plot he investigates, the game's historian chooses the truth and accepts the risk that burned his ancestor. The game sides against Borges's elegant fatalism and against Simon's bookish quietism, and in doing so takes up the burden both declined: the burden of believing in factual truth (Chapter 11).

5.4 Philology as heresy

The instrument by which the Church's founding narrative is undone is a document, and the method by which documents undo institutions has a precise history. In 1440 Lorenzo Valla demonstrated, in his *De falso credita et ementita Constantini donatione declamatio*, that the Donation of Constantine, the charter by which the emperor had supposedly granted the papacy temporal dominion over the West, was a forgery, exposing in its Latin anachronisms that no author of the fourth century could have written. Valla wrote under the protection of Alfonso of Aragon, then at war with the pope: philology as heresy required a prince. The Germonik Scriptures are a Vallan document. They do not refute the Church's doctrine; they undo the Church's title. Like Valla's treatise, they cannot circulate without a protector, and in Ivalice there is none. Their fate within the story is stranger still. The same book holds the rituals that open the portal from Orbonne to the Necrohol of Mullonde, and once Ramza has been made to surrender it to the Templars at Mullonde, Folmarv uses it to open the way below. The text that unmasks the false saint is also the key to the crypt in which the false saint is to rise. Truth and its demonic use are bound into one volume, and the Church's suppression of the book was, in this sense, also the custody of a gate.

5.5 Mnemohistory and counter-memory

Jan Assmann distinguished history, the study of the past as it happened, from mnemohistory, the study of the past as it is remembered (*Moses the Egyptian*, 1997). The distinction does not dismiss memory as error; it analyses memory's work, the way a remembered past founds identities, licenses institutions, and draws the boundaries of a community. Assmann's subject was the Mosaic distinction between true and false religion and the counter-memories it provoked. The Glabados Church is a mnemohistorical institution par excellence. It is founded not on what Ajora did but on what is remembered of him, and its authority consists in the administration of that memory. The Germonik Scriptures are what Foucault called a counter-memory, a term that entered English through the collection *Language, Counter-Memory, Practice* (1977): a memory that contests the official one not by supplementing it but by disclosing its construction.

5.6 The victim displaced: Girard read through Ivalice

Girard's thesis (*Des choses cachées depuis la fondation du monde*, 1978; *Le Bouc émissaire*, 1982) is that archaic religion conceals the founding murder by representing the victim first as guilty and then as sacred, while the Gospels uniquely reveal the mechanism by taking the side of the victim's innocence. *Final Fantasy Tactics* performs a double operation upon this scheme.

First, the Germonik Scriptures demystify the Church's victim. Ajora was not an innocent lamb but a political agent, and the Church's narrative of his innocent martyrdom is itself the myth. The game thereby demystifies the very kind of text that, on Girard's account, demystified myth, a second-order unmasking that Girard's theology cannot easily accommodate. Second, the game transfers the revelatory function from scripture to historiography. The true innocent expelled by the community is Ramza, branded a heretic and erased from the record, and the text that reveals his innocence is not a gospel but the Durai Papers. The game is Girardian in structure and anti-Girardian in theology. It agrees that the revelation of a victim's innocence is the work of a text, but denies that the founding text of the religion performed it. Revelation passes from the sacred canon to the secular archive.

5.7 Archons of the zodiac

Gnostic cosmology, as reconstructed by Hans Jonas (*The Gnostic Religion*, 1958) and made widely legible after the discovery of the Nag Hammadi codices in 1945 by Elaine Pagels (*The Gnostic Gospels*, 1979), imagines a cosmos ruled by archons, planetary and zodiacal powers that imprison the divine spark in matter. The ignorant demiurge at their head, named Ialdabaoth in the *Apocryphon of John*, boasts that he is God and that there is no other. Salva-

tion is *gnosis*: knowledge of one's origin, which permits the soul to ascend past the guardians of the spheres.

The Lucavi are zodiacal archons in the strictest sense: twelve powers bound to the signs, ruling human desire from within the stones, and led by a sovereign, Ultima, the High Seraph, who masquerades as the Church's saint. The Gnostic structure is complete except at the decisive point. In Gnosticism knowledge saves the soul from the cosmos. In *Final Fantasy Tactics* knowledge saves nothing but the record. The Germonik Scriptures liberate no one from the archons; Ramza must face them with sword and spell. The game's gnosis is political rather than soteriological. It does not redeem the knower; it redeems the past.

Chapter Six

Constellations of the Pact

Zodiac Stones and Lucavi

6.1 The legend inverted

The Church's monumental history includes the legend of the Zodiac Braves: twelve heroes who, bearing stones marked with the signs, vanquished a demonic power in an earlier age. The legend is the realm's heroic foundation and the stones are its relics, sought by Church, crown, and merchant alike. The narrative inverts the legend. The stones are not weapons against the demons; they are the demons' vessels. The Lucavi dwell within them and enter into those who, holding a stone in an extremity of desire or despair, consent to the pact. Belias (1998: Velius), of Aries, takes Wiegraf. Cúchulainn (Queklain), of Scorpio, takes Cardinal Delacroix. Zalera, of Gemini, takes Marquis Elmdor. Adrammelech (Adramelk), of Capricorn, takes Dycedarg. Hashmal (Hashmalum), of Leo, takes Folmarv. Ultima (Altima), of Virgo, is to take Alma. The legend of the Braves is a history of possession retold as a history of heroism.

Euhemerus of Messene, writing around 300 BCE, proposed that the gods were deified men, kings and benefactors remembered beyond death as divinities. The game performs a reverse euhemerism. Its heroes were possessed men, or demons heroized; its relics are prisons; its sacred history is the camouflage of an infernal one.

The legend's own details sharpen the inversion. In the account every child of Ivalice learns, the Zodiac Braves rose twice: once against a demon summoned by an ancient king of Mullonde, and again in Ajora's time against one summoned by the liege lord of Limberry. Simon's notes in the Scriptures judge the second demon an ecclesiastical invention, devised to turn a spy into a saint. Yet the lord of Limberry in the game's present, Marquis Elmdor, is the host of the Lucavi Zalera. The Church's fiction acquires a real successor, as though a lie told long enough about demons had summoned the demons it described. Ramza, closing the Scriptures, draws the same double conclusion: the saint's miracles were false, but the darkness he has seen in the stones is not.

Benjamin's epistemo-critical prologue to the *Trauerspiel* book supplies the governing metaphor: *"Die Ideen verhalten sich zu den Dingen wie die Sternbilder zu den Sternen."* Ideas

are to things as constellations are to stars. A constellation is not in the stars; it is a configuration in which they are read. The zodiac is the paradigm of such a configuration, and the Church's legend arranges the twelve signs into a heroic figure. The task the game assigns its historian is to re-constellate the same stars, to read the same points as a different figure. The Durai Papers discover no new stars. They draw new lines.

6.2 The pact

The pact with a demon has a canonical literary history. Marlowe's *Doctor Faustus* (c. 1592) signs in his own blood for twenty-four years of power; Goethe's Faust (Part I, 1808) wagers his soul on the moment he would bid to stay. Goethe's Mephistopheles introduces himself as *"Ein Teil von jener Kraft, / Die stets das Böse will und stets das Gute schafft"*: part of that power which always wills evil and always works good. Ivalice's Church is Mephistopheles inverted, part of that power which always wills the good and always works evil. The pact-makers' profiles compose a typology of political passions: Wiegraf's despair after his sister's death; Delacroix's covetousness; Elmdor's aristocratic self-regard; Dycedarg's dynastic ambition, which had already led him to poison his father; Folmarv's zeal for order, which at Riovanes kills his own son Isilud for weakness rather than bargain for him, and which ends in the Necrohol with Hashmal taking his own life as an offering to Ultima. The pact consumes lineage from both ends: a son poisons his father, and a father kills his son. Each pact is struck at a moment of lack. The stone answers a wound.

Miura's *Berserk* supplies the closest modern analogue: the Behelit, a stone egg bearing a scrambled human face, which activates at the moment of its bearer's utmost despair and summons the God Hand to offer apotheosis in exchange for sacrifice. Griffith's Eclipse and Wiegraf's pact share a structure, in which a man broken by the failure of his cause is offered a power that redeems the failure by abolishing the self that failed. But *Berserk* makes the sacrifice of comrades the price, while *Final Fantasy Tactics* makes the price the self. The Lucavi do not require Wiegraf to deliver his companions. They require Wiegraf.

6.3 Diabolical powers and the return of the gods

Weber's two vocational lectures supply the decisive frames. In *Politik als Beruf*, discussed in Chapter 2, the diabolical powers that lurk in all violence are the price of political action. In *Wissenschaft als Beruf* (delivered 1917, published 1919), Weber described the condition of a disenchanted world in which the old gods return as impersonal forces: *"Die alten vielen Götter, entzaubert und daher in Gestalt unpersönlicher Mächte, entsteigen ihren Gräbern, streben nach Gewalt über unser Leben und beginnen untereinander wieder ihren ewigen Kampf."* The many old gods, disenchanted and therefore in the form of impersonal powers, rise from their graves, strive for power over our lives, and resume among themselves their eternal struggle.

The sentence reads like a synopsis of the Lucavi. Ivalice is a world at once disenchanted and re-enchanted: disenchanted, because its saint is shown to have been a man and its sacred history a political artefact; re-enchanted, because the demons are real. Weber's paradox, that disenchantment does not abolish the gods but returns them as impersonal value-powers, is the game's metaphysics. The Lucavi are not persons. They are passions with names, dwelling in stones and rising from their graves into human hosts. Their signs compose a polytheism of political values (dominion, vengeance, vanity, order, resurrection), and their war is Weber's eternal struggle waged in human bodies.

As an allegorical procession the Lucavi recall Prudentius's *Psychomachia* (c. 405), the first sustained allegory of the soul's war, in which Virtues and Vices fight as armed women across the field of the soul. In *Final Fantasy Tactics* the field is a realm and the soul is political. The psychomachia has become a war of the passions of rule.

6.4 Stones as capital

The pursuit of the stones is an accumulation. Templars gather them; a trading house's designs upon them entangle Mustadio's father in the second chapter; cardinals hoard them. Marx called the violent process by which the preconditions of capital were first assembled the so-called primitive accumulation (*Das Kapital* I, 1867, Part VIII), whose history, he wrote, is inscribed in the annals of mankind *mit Zügen von Blut und Feuer*, in letters of blood and fire. The stones are a capital of desire: each converts a human lack into force, and the institution holding the most stones commands the most force. They are, however, capital of a peculiar kind, for they appreciate in blood. The Lucavi require a war's bloodshed to accomplish their sovereign's resurrection, so that every death in the Lion War is a deposit toward Ultima's body.

Georges Bataille's general economy (*La Part maudite*, 1949) holds that every society produces a surplus it must expend, gloriously or catastrophically, and that war is one form of the expenditure. Ivalice after fifty years of war carries a surplus of soldiers and of grievance, and the Lion War spends it. But the Lucavi pervert Bataille's sovereignty. Bataillean expenditure is sumptuary and unproductive, a consumption without return; the Lucavi spend blood in order to accumulate a body. They are capitalists of sacrifice who convert expenditure into accumulation, which is precisely the operation by which, on Bataille's account, the bourgeois world betrays the sacred.

6.5 Mythic violence and divine violence

Benjamin's "Zur Kritik der Gewalt" (1921) distinguishes law-making violence, which founds orders, from law-preserving violence, which maintains them. Both belong to mythic violence, which Benjamin opposes to divine violence: *"Die mythische Gewalt ist Blutgewalt über das*

bloße Leben um ihrer selbst willen, die göttliche reine Gewalt über alles Leben um des Lebendigen willen." Mythic violence is blood-violence over mere life for its own sake; divine violence is pure violence over all life for the sake of the living. Mythic violence makes law and threatens; divine violence destroys law, expiates, and strikes; the one is bloody, the other *auf unblutige Weise letal*, lethal in a bloodless way. And divine violence, Benjamin adds, is not recognizable with certainty by human beings.

The map is exact. Delita's violence is law-making: it founds a dynasty. The violence of Church and nobility is law-preserving: it defends titles and doctrines. The Lucavi's violence is mythic violence in its purest form, blood-violence over mere life, for the blood of the war is literally the material of their sovereign's body. Ramza's violence is the only candidate for the divine. It destroys a mythic order without founding any order of its own; it expiates Zeakden by restoring Alma to herself; and it is unrecognizable, since history does not record it at all.

The objection is obvious: Ramza's battles are as bloody as anyone's. The answer lies in the game's distinction between what a battle spills and what it yields. The Lucavi's battles yield blood toward a body; Ramza's last battle yields a body withheld from blood. The game's mechanics, moreover, supply an emblem of bloodless lethality in the crystal into which the fallen are transfigured, a death without effusion, a life converted not into blood but into light (Chapter 10). Divine violence in Benjamin's sense is unrecognizable in its moment. *Final Fantasy Tactics* makes it recognizable only in retrospect, and only to a historian.

6.6 Rings, Silmarils, and the runesword

Tolkien supplies the Anglophone tradition's master-image of the corrupting object of power: the One Ring, which grants power by consuming its bearer and which only renunciation can defeat (*The Lord of the Rings*, 1954–1955). The kinship with the Zodiac Stones is plain, and so is the difference in the hero's relation to them. Frodo carries the Ring in order to destroy it; Ramza's company carries stones throughout its campaign, for the player accumulates them as the Lucavi fall, and never makes the pact. In the texts of 1997 and 2007 the stones pass through Ramza's hands as the Ring passes briefly through Sam's: held, not used. The 2025 remaster revises the image, letting Ramza spend them at the last to carry himself and Alma out of the collapsing graveyard (Chapter 10). *The Silmarillion* (1977) offers a deeper analogue. The Silmarils hold a light that can never be remade, and Fëanor's oath to recover them drives his house into kin-slaying and ruin. The Zodiac Stones are anti-Silmarils, holding not light but demons, and they too drive a house into kin-slaying. The house of Beoulve is destroyed by its eldest son's pact, its second son's reanimated corpse, and its youngest son's heresy.

Michael Moorcock's Elric cycle supplies the third analogue: Stormbringer, the black runesword that drinks souls and lends their strength to its bearer, in a cosmos divided

between Law and Chaos. Matsuno's *Tactics Ogre* inherited the dualism; *Final Fantasy Tactics* annuls it. Its demon of Leo, Hashmal, is styled in the retranslation the Bringer of Order; its Templars serve order; and the order they serve is infernal. Where Moorcock balances Law against Chaos, the game finds the demonic on the side of Law, which is the side of institutions.

6.7 The thirteenth sign

At the bottom of Midlight's Deep (1998: Deep Dungeon), an optional abyss beneath the trade city of Warjilis, waits the game's thirteenth zodiacal power, Elidibus, bearer of Serpentarius, from whom a sufficiently persistent player may learn to summon Zodiark, a power that bears the name of the whole zodiac. Ophiuchus, the Serpent-bearer, is a real constellation that the ecliptic crosses and that astrological convention excludes from the twelve. The game hides it at the bottom of the world.

Giorgio Agamben's figure of inclusive exclusion (*Homo sacer*, 1995), the structure by which a system is constituted through what it excludes, and Schmitt's exception, which reveals the sovereign by suspending the norm, both find an emblem in the thirteenth sign. The twelve are twelve because the thirteenth is excluded, and the summons that names the whole zodiac belongs to the excluded one. The truth of the system lies beneath the system, accessible only to those who descend beyond what the plot requires. It is the game's quietest proposition and perhaps its most radical: the order's name is held by what the order omits.



PART THREE

The Order of the Grid

Quis hunc nostrum chamaeleonta non admiretur?
Who would not admire this chameleon of ours?

GIOVANNI PICO DELLA MIRANDOLA, *ORATIO DE HOMINIS DIGNITATE*, 1486

Chapter Seven

The Art of the Weak

Tactics, Strategy, and the Placeless Hero

7.1 The title as thesis

The game is called *Tactics*. In the vocabulary of military theory since Clausewitz, who defined tactics as the doctrine of the use of armed forces in the engagement and strategy as the doctrine of the use of engagements for the object of the war (*Vom Kriege*, 1832, II.1), the title merely names the scale of play: engagements rather than campaigns, the grid rather than the map. Michel de Certeau's displacement of the two terms reveals a deeper accuracy (*L'Invention du quotidien*, vol. 1, *Arts de faire*, 1980). For de Certeau, a strategy is the calculus of forces that becomes possible once a subject of will and power (an army, a city, an enterprise, an institution) can be isolated and can postulate a place of its own, a *propre*, from which it manages its relations with an exterior of targets and threats. A tactic is a calculated action determined by the absence of a proper place. It operates on a terrain imposed and organized by a foreign power; it acts blow by blow, seizing opportunities on the wing; it has no base where it might stockpile its winnings. It is, in de Certeau's formula, an art of the weak. Strategy privileges space and seeks to master time by reducing it to place; tactics depend on time.

Read through de Certeau, the title names the art the narrative honours and the condition its hero comes to occupy.

7.2 A chiasmus

Ramza begins with the most proper place in Ivalice short of the throne: the house of Beoulve, first among the realm's military houses, with its name, its seat at Eagrose, and its command of the Order of the Northern Sky. In the course of the game he is divested of every proper. He leaves his house after Zeakden; he serves as a sellsword in Gaffgarion's company with his name set aside; the Church brands him a heretic; the official record erases him. He ends with no house, no name, no church, no state, and, as Chapter 11 will show, no certain grave. He becomes the pure tactician. He fights always on another's ground, in other men's castles, cities,

monasteries, and ruins; he seizes occasions; he stockpiles nothing he can keep, and in the texts of 1997 and 2007 even the stones he gathers he will not use.

Delita traverses the inverse path, from the most improper of positions, a commoner orphan lodged in a noble household by grace, to the most proper of all, the throne. He abandons tactics for strategy at the moment he acquires a place to defend. The two protagonists thus compose a chiasmus: the noble descends into tactics, the commoner ascends into strategy. The chiasmus carries a moral valence that de Certeau's analysis already implies. A proper place is also a constraint; it must be held, garrisoned, justified, and recorded. The strategist accumulates because he must, and he is vulnerable to those who have nothing to lose. Only the one who has lost his place remains free, and the one who has acquired it is imprisoned by it. The final image of Delita, alone in a ruined chapel and alone in a kingdom, is the image of a strategist held captive by his *propre*.

7.3 Poaching

De Certeau's paradigm of the tactical is reading, which he described as poaching (*lire: un braconnage*): the reader is a nomad who crosses fields he did not write, takes what he can use, and carries it elsewhere, never owning the land. Henry Jenkins extended the figure to the fan cultures that appropriate the texts of the culture industries (*Textual Poachers*, 1992). *Final Fantasy Tactics* contains a literal poaching. A support ability (1998: Secret Hunt; 2007: Poach) converts the carcass of a monster slain by its bearer into goods offered at a specialist shop, the Fur Shop of the first translation and the Poachers' Den of the second. The mechanic is a miniature of the tactical economy: the poacher works on land he does not own, takes from creatures he did not raise, and turns the take into currency elsewhere. The thief's arts, which steal weapons, armour, money, experience, and even hearts, belong to the same economy. Proudhon's provocation that property is theft (*Qu'est-ce que la propriété?*, 1840) is answered on the grid in kind: theft is the tactic of the propertyless.

The Durai Papers are a poaching in de Certeau's sense. The historian takes from the archive of the victors what it would not give, and carries it into a field the victors do not own.

7.4 War machine and grid

Deleuze and Guattari contrast chess and Go as games of the State and of the nomad (*Mille plateaux*, plateau 12). Chess pieces are coded: each has an intrinsic nature from which its movements derive, and the game institutes a regulated war upon a striated space. Go pieces are anonymous pellets with only a collective and situational function, deployed across a smooth space without fronts. The units of *Final Fantasy Tactics* are chess pieces by vocation and Go pellets by origin. A Knight is a knight; but the generic recruit who is a Knight today was a Squire last month and may be a Summoner next, carrying with him, as secondary arts

and reactions, the skills of every vocation through which he has passed. The job system decodes the chess piece. The unit is a coded figure whose code is mutable: a deterritorialized chess piece.

The grid itself is striation in its purest form, space divided into tiles and height into measured increments. Yet the terrain reintroduces qualitative difference into metric space. Deep water drowns movement, marsh slows it, height lengthens a bow's reach and forbids a short leap. The grid striates; the terrain smooths. And the two modes of organization the plateau describes are distributed across the narrative exactly. Ramza's company is a nomad war machine, without territory, sustained by errands and spoils, moving across the realm and belonging to none of its powers. Delita is the State apparatus, which possesses no war machine of its own and captures those of others, Goltana's army and the Church's knights, converting them into his.

7.5 The job system as Pico's *Oration*

Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* imagines God addressing Adam, to whom he has given no fixed seat, no form of his own, and no function peculiar to him, so that he may fashion himself as he chooses: *"Poteris in inferiora quae sunt bruta degenerare; poteris in superiora quae sunt divina ex tui animi sententia regenerari."* You may degenerate into the lower things, which are brutes; you may, by the judgement of your soul, be reborn into the higher things, which are divine. Man is the chameleon of creation, admirable because he has no nature but the one he makes.

The job system is an *Oration* in mechanical form. Every generic unit begins in one of two universal origins, the Squire and the Chemist, the sword and the remedy, and may become by labour (job points, earned through action) any of twenty vocations. The two origins already contain a philosophy. The Chemist's art is a *pharmakon* in the double sense Derrida drew from Plato ("La pharmacie de Platon," 1968): the Phoenix Down that restores the fallen destroys the undead upon whom it is thrown, so that remedy and poison are the same feather. The last of the generic vocations, the Mime, who repeats the actions of allies and has no art of his own, is Pico's chameleon made a class: the being whose nature is to have none. And the Lucavi transformation is Pico's degeneration, the human who, by the judgement of his soul, descends into the form of a beast. The game holds both trajectories. Ascent is by vocation; descent is by pact.

The political significance lies in a dissonance. The mechanics are meritocratic: any generic unit may become anything by labour, and a share of the job points a unit earns spills over to allies in the field who have opened the same vocation, so that learning is social and vocation a commons. The narrative is aristocratic: birth assigns station, and the commoner who rises must do so by crime. The dissonance is not an incoherence. It is the game's political argu-

ment. The system shows what Ivalice could be, a republic of capacities in which vocation follows labour; the story shows what Ivalice is, a haemocracy.

Yet the grid is not innocent of the order it implicitly criticizes. The named characters carry vocations no generic unit can acquire: Agrias's Holy Knight, Mustadio's Machinist, and above all Count Orlandeau's sword arts, whose power players have long regarded as disproportionate to anything labour can produce. The grid is a meritocracy for the anonymous and an aristocracy for the named. In Weber's terms, the generic's job is an office, attainable by qualification, while the hero's gift is charisma, attached to a person and not transferable. The player's experience of the grid's two classes reproduces, in miniature, the order of the realm.

7.6 Geomancy and the production of space

The Geomancer's arts produce effects determined by the ground beneath the target: one upon grass, another upon water, another upon sand or stone or marsh. The Geomancer has no power of his own; his power is the terrain's. This is tactics in its purest mechanical form, the art of making another's ground fight for you. Watsuji Tetsurō argued in *Fūdo* (1935) that human existence is constituted by its milieu, the climate, soil, and landscape in which a people lives, so that ethics cannot be separated from place; Nishida Kitarō's logic of *basho* (from 1926) made place the condition of determination itself. The Geomancer is a practitioner of *fūdo*: an agent whose agency is the landscape's.

Henri Lefebvre insisted that space is not a container but a social product (*La Production de l'espace*, 1974). The battlefields of *Final Fantasy Tactics* are produced spaces, and their typology is a social topography of the realm. Castles belong to the nobility, monasteries and cathedrals to the Church, trade cities to merchants, plains and forests to no one and therefore to the commons and the outlaws. Where one fights tells one whose ground one stands upon. Ramza fights almost always on the ground of others. The one battle he fights in his own house, at Eagrose, is fought against his own blood, the eldest brother transformed into Adrammelech. The proper place, when he returns to it, is occupied by a demon.

7.7 Clausewitz inverted, Sun Tzu fulfilled

Clausewitz's dictum that war is a mere continuation of politics by other means (*"Der Krieg ist eine bloße Fortsetzung der Politik mit anderen Mitteln," Vom Kriege* I.1 §24) was inverted by Foucault in the lectures of 1976: politics is the continuation of war by other means, and the peace of the State is a war that continues inside its institutions. Ivalice confirms Foucault. The peace that ended the Fifty Years' War is the continuation of that war by other means, against the veterans, against the commons, and between the dukes.

The oldest of the strategists supplies the other half of the picture: 兵者，詭道也, war is the way of deception (*Sunzi bingfa*, "Laying Plans"). Delita is a Sunzian. Ramza scarcely de-

ceives, and that is at once his tactical weakness and his historical salvation, for only one who did not deceive can be the subject of a history whose purpose is to undeceive.

7.8 Arms, letters, and the gun

One vocation stands outside the anthropology the rest of the grid assumes. Mustadio Bunansa, a machinist of Goug, the city whose engineers excavate the devices of a vanished age, fights with a gun, and his father is seized by a trading house that covets the stone in his son's keeping. Ordinary firearms in *Final Fantasy Tactics* deal damage determined by the weapon alone. The wielder's strength and Bravery do not enter into it, and neither does the target's Faith. The gun is the one weapon indifferent to the soul. It belongs, accordingly, to commoners and merchants rather than to knights, and it arrives from a dig rather than a forge, as if the future of violence had to be excavated from the past.

Historians since Michael Roberts ("The Military Revolution, 1560–1660," 1956) and Geoffrey Parker (*The Military Revolution*, 1988) have described how gunpowder weapons, drilled infantry, and new fortifications dissolved the military monopoly of the armoured nobility and fed the growth of centralized states. Cervantes gave the transformation its elegy. In Don Quixote's discourse on arms and letters (*Don Quijote* I.37–38), the knight blesses the ages that lacked *"aquestos endemoniados instrumentos de la artillería"*, these devilish instruments of artillery, whose inventor he supposes to be receiving his reward in hell, because they allow a cowardly hand to take the life of a valiant knight. Miyazaki's *Princess Mononoke* (1997) gave the same transformation an emancipatory face. In Lady Eboshi's ironworks, women bought out of brothels work the bellows and lepers make the guns, and firearms let the outcast stand against samurai and gods alike.

Final Fantasy Tactics holds both readings, and it adds a third that bears on its historiography. Quixote's discourse concludes that arms are nobler than letters, because arms defend the commonwealth at greater cost. The game reverses the verdict. Ramza's arms are erased from the record; Orran's letters survive their author's burning and outlast the regime that burned him. In Ivalice letters are not the servants of arms but their only memory. And the gun, the weapon that knows nothing of Faith or Bravery, joins the Arithmetician (Chapter 8) as the second herald of a disenchanted order: violence calculated from the properties of the instrument rather than the qualities of the person.

Chapter Eight

Chronopolitics

Charge Time and the Arithmetic of Death

8.1 From Active Time to Charge Time

Hiroyuki Ito's Active Time Battle, introduced in *Final Fantasy IV* (1991), brought real time into turn-based combat. Gauges filled continuously, the battle did not wait for the player, and hesitation had a cost. *Final Fantasy Tactics* discretizes that pressure. Time advances in ticks. At each tick every unit's charge time rises by its Speed, and when it reaches one hundred the unit acts; a unit that forgoes moving or acting returns to the field sooner. Spells and many arts must be charged before they resolve, and during the interval the caster waits while the world moves, so that a spell aimed at ground rather than at a person may find the ground empty when it lands. A list at the edge of the screen displays the order of the turns to come. Time becomes legible, calculable, and manipulable. The anxiety of Active Time gives way to a lucidity that is more unsettling, because the future is now visible and can be planned.

8.2 The visible future

The turn list is the image of homogeneous time: a queue of discrete and equivalent moments, each waiting to be filled with an action. Bergson's critique of spatialized time (*Essai sur les données immédiates de la conscience*, 1889) held that clock time represents lived duration as a line of juxtaposed, homogeneous instants, and so falsifies the qualitative interpenetration of the moments of consciousness. Benjamin turned the critique into a philosophy of history. The idea of progress, he argued, cannot be separated from the idea of history's course through *homogene und leere Zeit*, homogeneous and empty time (Thesis XIII), whereas *"Die Geschichte ist Gegenstand einer Konstruktion, deren Ort nicht die homogene und leere Zeit sondern die von Jetztzeit erfüllte bildet"* (Thesis XIV): history is the object of a construction whose site is not homogeneous, empty time but time filled by the presence of the now.

The turn list is homogeneous empty time made visible, and it is, in de Certeau's terms, the strategist's dream: time reduced to space, the future arranged as a sequence of places to be occupied. The player who reads it well becomes a strategist of time, converting what is to

come into a schedule. The art of the tactician, by contrast, is to find within the schedule the moment that is not on it.

8.3 Sovereignty over the turn

The Time Mage's arts (Haste, Slow, Stop, Immobilize, Quick, Float, Reflect, and the gravitational and meteoric magics) are powers over this schedule. Schmitt made the decision on the exception the mark of the sovereign and compared the exception in jurisprudence to the miracle in theology. On the grid, sovereignty is the decision on the turn. Quick, which grants a unit an immediate turn out of order, is a miracle in Schmitt's precise sense, a suspension of the normal order of time by decision. Stop, which freezes a unit's time, is its converse: the sovereign withdrawal of someone's future.

Benjamin's theses name a cessation of another kind: *"das Zeichen einer messianischen Stillstellung des Geschehens, anders gesagt, einer revolutionären Chance im Kampfe für die unterdrückte Vergangenheit"* (Thesis XVII), the sign of a messianic arrest of happening or, put differently, of a revolutionary chance in the fight for the oppressed past. The Stop spell is the profane counterfeit of that arrest. It halts not history but a single person within it, and it does so for another's advantage. The game holds the messianic standstill in reserve for its frame, where the historian's papers arrest the flow of the official chronicle and seize the oppressed past at the moment of its danger.

8.4 The interval between decision and effect

The charged spell is the game's most exact image of political action. The caster decides now; the effect arrives later; in the interval the caster stands exposed and the world moves. Weber's ethic of responsibility obliges the politician to answer for the foreseeable consequences of his acts, but consequences arrive in a world that has changed since the decision was made. Arendt described action as boundless and unpredictable (*The Human Condition*, 1958). Its consequences escape the actor into a web of relations no one controls, and its only remedies are the promise, which binds an uncertain future, and forgiveness, which releases an irreversible past. The charge interval is the time of the promise. The caster has committed, the world must be held to the commitment, and it may not be.

The two scalars of the subject (Chapter 9) are also two relations to this interval. Faith governs magic, and magic must be charged: it is a commitment to what is not yet. Bravery governs reactions, and reactions are instantaneous: they answer what is already here. Augustine's analysis of time in the eleventh book of the *Confessions* supplies the frame: *"praesens de praeteritis memoria, praesens de praesentibus contuitus, praesens de futuris expectatio"* (XI.20.26). The present of things past is memory, the present of things present is attention, the present of things to come is expectation. Faith is *expectatio*; Bravery is *contuitus*; and the crystal, as

Chapter 10 will argue, is *memoria*. A unit on the grid is a soul in Augustine's sense, distended across three times.

8.5 Arithmeticks: death by attribute

The Arithmetician (1998: Calculator) casts any spell it has learned in other vocations instantly and without cost, upon every unit on the field, friend or foe, whose charge time, level, experience, or height satisfies a numerical predicate: a multiple of three, four, or five, or a prime. It is the most notorious power in the game, and it turns battle into a demographic problem. The player who masters it must calibrate the levels and heights of his own soldiers so that the predicate selects only the enemy; the commander becomes the demographer of his own army. The Arithmetician is, moreover, a scholar. *Final Fantasy Tactics* locates the summit of violence not in faith, nor in courage, nor in the demonic pact, but in calculation.

The genealogy of this figure is the genealogy of modern administrative violence. Weber described rationalization as the progressive subjection of life to calculable rules, and its outcome as the *stahlhartes Gehäuse*, the casing hard as steel that the English tradition calls the iron cage (*Die protestantische Ethik und der Geist des Kapitalismus*, 1904–1905). Horkheimer and Adorno traced enlightenment's reduction of the qualitative to the quantitative and its suspicion of whatever cannot be reckoned (*Dialektik der Aufklärung*, 1944/1947). Ian Hacking described the avalanche of printed numbers through which nineteenth-century states learned to govern populations as statistical aggregates (*The Taming of Chance*, 1990). Foucault, in the final lecture of 1976, described the emergence, beside the sovereign right to take life, of a power to make live and let die, exercised over populations through their measurable properties. Arendt's report on the trial of Adolf Eichmann (*Eichmann in Jerusalem*, 1963) gave the figure its human face. Eichmann, the SS officer who organized the deportation of Europe's Jews to the ghettos and extermination camps, appeared in Jerusalem not as a fanatic but as a functionary who had sent millions to their deaths through timetables, categories, and quotas, and who seemed unable to think from the standpoint of anyone else. The comparison that follows is formal, not moral. A game's arithmetic of units is not an atrocity. What the Arithmetician shares with the history Arendt studied is only the structure she identified as new: selection for death by category, rather than by anything a person has done.

The Arithmetician kills by attribute. Its target is not a person but a property: a level that happens to be prime, a height divisible by four. Schmitt's criterion of the political, the distinction between friend and enemy, is abolished, since the predicate cannot tell them apart; only the commander's prior calibration of his own army keeps the blast from his own ranks. The Arithmetician is the end of politics in Schmitt's sense and the beginning of administration. It is also the end of tactics. Its spells need no position, no terrain, no timing, and no line

of sight; they require only a number. The game's most powerful art is the one that abolishes the game's art.

8.6 Kairos

The Greeks distinguished *chronos*, measured time, from *kairos*, the opportune moment. The turn list is *chronos*; the tactician lives in *kairos*. De Certeau insists that tactics depend on time, on the occasion seized on the wing, because they have no place in which to wait. The player's art on the grid is to discover *kairos* within *chronos*: the turn at which an enemy caster's charge leaves him exposed, the step that places a unit just beyond the edge of a spell aimed at the ground, the moment at which a reaction will answer an attack before the attacker can act again. Strategy spatializes time; tactics temporalize space. Ramza, the tactician, is a figure of time. Delita, the strategist, is a figure of place, and his story ends in one: a ruined chapel, with the flowers he brought, and no more turns to come.

8.7 The count of the fallen

One further feature of the clock bears on everything that follows. When a unit falls, a numeral appears above it, a three, and each time its turn would have come the numeral falls by one. Death on the grid is not a point but a duration, measured in the dead's own time. The fallen continue to have turns, and they spend them in diminishing. What happens when the count reaches zero is the subject of Chapter 10.

Chapter Nine

The Scalar Subject

Faith, Bravery, and the Speech That Moves Them

9.1 A minimal anthropology

Every unit in *Final Fantasy Tactics* carries two numbers. Faith multiplies magical efficacy in both directions: the higher a unit's Faith, the stronger the magic it casts and the stronger the magic it receives, whether that magic wounds or heals. Bravery governs the likelihood that most reactive abilities will fire, the force of the bare hand and of certain weapons, and, inversely, the chance that a unit stepping upon hidden treasure will find the rare item rather than the common one. Both can be moved in battle by speech and by spells, and a quarter of each movement persists after the battle ends. Both have thresholds of exit. A unit whose permanent Faith reaches ninety-five or more departs the company after battle to devote itself to the Church; a unit whose permanent Bravery falls below six deserts as well, too frightened to fight on. Within a battle, a unit whose Bravery collapses below ten is transformed into a chicken and flees, regaining a point of courage each turn until it reaches ten again.

Two scalars, mutable by speech and experience and bounded by exits: this is the game's anthropology, the minimal model of a person it requires. It replaces the alignment system of *Tactics Ogre* (Introduction, I.4), in which moral orientation was a choice made at the forks of the plot, with a pair of continuously variable dispositions carried by every person in the world. The result is a philosophy of the subject compressed into two numbers, and its propositions can be read directly off the rules.

9.2 Faith as permeability

Faith, in the game's grammar, is not assent to a doctrine. It is openness to the transcendent, and it is indifferent to what enters through the opening. Grace and harm arrive by the same channel; to be capable of being healed is to be capable of being wounded. Friedrich Schleiermacher located the essence of religion in the feeling of absolute dependence, *das schlechthinnige Abhängigkeitsgefühl* (*Der christliche Glaube*, 1821–1822). The game's high-Faith units

are its most potent casters and its most fragile targets, dependent upon the magic of others as much as they dispense their own. Faith is power as dependency.

The threshold of exit converts this anthropology into a theology. A unit whose Faith approaches the absolute leaves the field for the cloister. Kierkegaard's knight of faith (*Frygt og Bæven*, 1843) is the one who, like Abraham, suspends the ethical for the sake of the religious, in the teleological suspension of the ethical. In Ivalice the knight of faith does not remain in history; he departs from it, and he departs to the Glabados Church, the very institution that betrays faith. The game's anthropology implies that perfect faith delivers the believer to the institution, and that the institution is the opposite of what he sought. Weber's ethic of conviction, in which the Christian does right and leaves the outcome to God, proves incompatible with remaining in the field at all.

The protagonists of the game's moral drama can be arranged as three suspensions. Abraham suspends the ethical for the religious. Ramza suspends the religious, the Church's authority over truth, for the ethical. Delita suspends both for the political. Kierkegaard had only the first; Ivalice supplies the other two.

At the opposite pole, a unit whose Faith is reduced to nothing (the status the retranslation calls Atheist and the first translation Innocent) is immune to all magic, harmful and healing alike. The disenchanted subject can be neither harmed nor saved by the transcendent. This is Weber's disenchantment rendered as a status effect: invulnerability purchased at the price of grace.

9.3 Enlightenment as a weapon

Among the Orator's arts is one that lowers its target's Faith (2007: Enlighten; 1998: Solution). Kant defined enlightenment as *"der Ausgang des Menschen aus seiner selbstverschuldeten Unmündigkeit"*, man's emergence from his self-incurred immaturity ("Beantwortung der Frage: Was ist Aufklärung?", 1784), an act each must perform for himself by daring to use his own understanding. On the grid enlightenment is not an emergence but an operation performed upon another, by an orator, to diminish a hostile caster's power. Horkheimer and Adorno's thesis that enlightenment becomes an instrument of domination and reverts to myth finds its emblem in a skill that uses persuasion to strip an enemy of faith for tactical advantage. The opposite art, Preach, raises Faith, strengthening an ally's spells while rendering him more vulnerable to the enemy's. The orator's two sermons are a single rhetoric pointed in two directions.

9.4 Bravery and the mean

Aristotle defined courage as the mean between cowardice and rashness, concerned with fear and confidence and above all with the fear of death in battle (*Nicomachean Ethics* III.6–9).

The game's Bravery is a scale with a floor but no true ceiling. Cowardice is punished, by the chicken and by desertion; rashness, the vice of excess, is not punished by death. Its only penalty is economic, and that penalty is the subject of the most philosophically pointed mechanic in the game.

9.5 The treasure of the timid

A movement ability allows a unit to find items hidden on certain tiles of a battlefield (1998: Move-Find Item; 2007: Treasure Hunter). Each such tile conceals a common item and a rare one, and which the unit finds depends on its Bravery: the lower the Bravery, the likelier the rare find. The timid find treasure.

The proposition has a long philosophical pedigree. In Kojève's reading of Hegel, the bondsman who feared death and refused the struggle becomes the one who works, transforms the world, and accumulates; the bourgeois is the slave become master of things but not of himself. Hobbes made the founding of the commonwealth the work of fear: *"The Passions that encline men to Peace, are Feare of Death; Desire of such things as are necessary to commodious living; and a Hope by their Industry to obtain them"* (*Leviathan*, ch. XIII). Fear founds commodious living; the commonwealth itself is the treasure of the timid. Nietzsche's last men, who have invented happiness and blink (*"Wir haben das Glück erfunden — sagen die letzten Menschen und blinzeln"*, *Also sprach Zarathustra*, Prologue §5), are its final beneficiaries.

The game encodes in a movement ability most players never consider the thesis that the prosperity of the bourgeois world is the reward of fear, while the brave, whose reactions fire and whose blows strike hardest, find only common things. The economy of Ivalice pays its cowards in treasure and its believers in exile.

9.6 Speech as force

The Orator's speechcraft (1998: Talk Skill) is a rhetoric of force. Its arts entice an enemy to change sides, stall a unit's turn, praise to raise Bravery, intimidate to lower it, preach to raise Faith, enlighten to lower it, condemn, beg, insult into berserk fury, and, in a parody of the Akademy's master, lecture the enemy to sleep. Louis Althusser described ideology as the interpellation of individuals as subjects, the hail to which one turns and, in turning, becomes the subject addressed ("Idéologie et appareils idéologiques d'État," 1970). Speechcraft literalizes interpellation. To be praised is to become braver, to be preached at is to become more faithful, and part of the change persists. The subject in Ivalice is partly constituted by the speech addressed to it.

J. L. Austin distinguished performative utterances, which do what they say, from statements that describe (*How to Do Things with Words*, 1962). Condemn (1998: Death Sen-

tence) is the performative that kills: it places upon its target a countdown at whose end the target dies. The illocutionary act of sentencing becomes a perlocutionary death. It is the Church's power in miniature, for to declare a heretic is to set the count.

Jürgen Habermas distinguished communicative action, oriented to mutual understanding, from strategic action, which uses speech as an instrument of success (*Theorie des kommunikativen Handelns*, 1981). Every art of speechcraft is strategic; none aims at understanding. On the battlefield of *Final Fantasy Tactics* there is no communicative action, only rhetoric as force: the condition Plato's Socrates diagnosed in the persuasion Gorgias taught, and the condition Thucydides staged in the Melian dialogue, where the strong do what they can and the weak suffer what they must (V.89). Speech oriented to understanding appears only outside battle, in Milleuda's question and Ovelia's accusation, and there it fails.

Entice deserves particular notice. That an enemy soldier can be talked across the line means that allegiance in Ivalice is contingent, a matter of persuasion rather than of blood or oath. Gramsci's hegemony, rule by consent rather than by force, is here a tactic exercised one soldier at a time. In a world where anyone may be persuaded to change sides, Agrias's fidelity (Chapter 3) acquires its full rarity.

9.7 Written in the stars

Every unit is born on a date, and its birthday assigns it a sign. The compatibility of the signs of attacker and target modifies the effect of blows and spells. Signs of the same element harmonize; signs standing in square conflict; and for signs in opposition the outcome depends on gender, best between a man and a woman and worst between two of the same sex. The scheme descends from the aspect doctrine Ptolemy codified in the *Tetrabiblos*, in which the trine is harmonious, the square hostile, and the opposition tense. The game's adaptation encodes a heterosexual cosmology into its mechanics, and it is joined by two vocations reserved each to one gender, the Bard to men and the Dancer to women, and by arts of charm that act only across the line of sex. Judith Butler described gender as a norm sustained by repetition and by the exclusions that constitute it (*Gender Trouble*, 1990). The universality of the job system is bounded by exactly two gendered exceptions and an astrology of opposite sexes; the Piconian freedom of the grid has a constitutive outside.

Pico himself, late in his short life, attacked judicial astrology in the *Disputationes adversus astrologiam divinatricem* (published 1496): if man can make himself, the stars cannot fix him. *Final Fantasy Tactics* holds both of Pico's positions at once, freedom of vocation within astral inclination, in the compromise the scholastic maxim expresses: *astra inclinant, non necessitant*, the stars incline but do not compel. For generic recruits, moreover, birthday and sign are the only biography the game provides. The chronicle records the anonymous as dates and signs. Astrology is the biography of those who have none.

9.8 The scalar subject

The Ivalician subject is a vector of two quantities, mutable by speech and experience and bounded by exits into the cloister and the hearth. Political existence is the zone between those thresholds: neither so faithful as to leave for the Church, nor so fearful as to leave for home. And since the player shapes the Faith and Bravery of every unit, Ramza's included, the player authors the soul of the hero. Sartre's existentialist maxim that existence precedes essence (*L'existentialisme est un humanisme*, 1946) returns with a twist: the essence is authored, but by another. The player is the Orator of his own army, and the most consequential speeches in the game are the ones he makes to his own soldiers.

Chapter Ten

The Triduum of the Count

Crystals, Chests, and the Economy of the Dead

10.1 The mechanics of death

When a unit's strength is exhausted it falls, and above the fallen body appears the numeral three. Each time its turn would have come, the count descends. While the count lasts the fallen may be raised: by the White Mage's Raise, by a Monk's art, by a Phoenix Down thrown from a Chemist's satchel. When the count reaches zero the unit is gone, permanently, and in its place lies one of two things, a crystal or a treasure chest. Another unit stepping upon the crystal is offered a choice between two goods: to have its own vitality and mana wholly restored, or to acquire abilities the dead had learned. A unit stepping upon the chest receives an item. There is one exception to the rule, and it proves the rule: if Ramza's count expires, the game ends. The hero cannot become an inheritance within the game. His inheritance is the text. Two further rules complete the system. The count runs on the dead unit's own clock, falling each time its charge time would have brought it a turn. And the undead are exempt: when their count expires they may rise again instead of crystallizing. The crystals themselves give off light, enough to brighten the dark floors of Midlight's Deep.

10.2 The triduum

Three counts mark the window within which the dead may rise, and the number is not neutral. The Christian *triduum*, from the Passion to the morning of the third day (*tertia die resurrexit a mortuis*, in the words of the Apostles' Creed), is the founding narrative of a window within which death may be undone. *Final Fantasy Tactics* secularizes the triduum. Within it, resurrection is available by technique and by commerce: the Phoenix Down, purchasable in any shop, restores the fallen to the field. The phoenix of Herodotus (II.73), which Clement of Rome offered to the Corinthians as a natural proof of the resurrection (1 Clement 25), has become a consumable. After the triduum lapses there is no resurrection, only transmission. The game draws the line with the precision of a creed: before the third count, restoration; after it, inheritance.

The Phoenix Down carries a second meaning. Thrown upon the undead, it destroys them (Chapter 7). The same feather that restores the dead to life annihilates the false life of corpses made to walk. In a world whose demons reanimate the dead, a remedy that discriminates true death from counterfeit life is a moral instrument, and it already contains the game's position: death may be undone only within its proper time, and life that persists beyond that time is not life. The rules make the point twice over, for the undead, who alone may rise again once the count has run out, are exactly the beings the feather destroys.

10.3 Force makes a thing

Simone Weil opened her essay on the *Iliad* with a definition: *"La force, c'est ce qui fait de quiconque lui est soumis une chose. Quand elle s'exerce jusqu'au bout, elle fait de l'homme une chose au sens le plus littéral, car elle en fait un cadavre"* ("L'Iliade ou le poème de la force," 1940–1941). Force is that which makes whoever is subjected to it into a thing. Exercised to the end, it makes a man a thing in the most literal sense, for it makes him a corpse.

Final Fantasy Tactics carries Weil's thesis beyond the corpse. The corpse itself is converted, at the toss of a hidden coin, into one of two kinds of thing. The chest is the dead as commodity: an item with an exchange value, saleable at the next shop. Marx's analysis of commodity fetishism (*Das Kapital* I, ch. 1, §4), in which relations between persons appear as relations between things, and Georg Lukács's extension of it into a theory of reification that penetrates every sphere of life (*Geschichte und Klassenbewußtsein*, 1923), find here their most literal emblem: a soldier's death yields a sword. The crystal is the dead as capacity, and it resists reification, because a capacity cannot be sold, only inherited.

The coin matters. Roger Caillois counted *alea*, chance, among the four fundamental categories of play (*Les Jeux et les hommes*, 1958). Here chance governs memory. The dead do not choose whether their lives become commodities or traditions, and neither do the living.

10.4 Inheritance as a task

At the crystal the heir must choose between consolation and capacity. Restoration of vitality and mana serves the present battle and is consumed in the using. The acquisition of abilities serves every battle to come and transforms the one who takes it. Jacques Derrida argued that inheritance is never a given but always a task (*Spectres de Marx*, 1993): one inherits only by selecting, filtering, and reaffirming, and a heritage is never at one with itself. The crystal stages Derrida's thesis with a precision no text could attain. The heir must decide, here and now, whether to use the dead for present relief or to carry them forward as the power to act.

Heidegger's account of authentic historicity (*Sein und Zeit*, 1927, §74) describes resolute retrieval (*Wiederholung*) as the explicit handing down of possibilities that have been, in which Dasein may choose its hero; in the same section he names the shared historizing of a

community, of a people, its *Geschick*, its destiny. The danger in that concept is not hypothetical. Heidegger joined the National Socialist party in May 1933 and, as rector of the University of Freiburg, summoned its students and teachers in his rectorial address of that month to the service of the new state; his private notebooks, published from 2014, contain antisemitic passages. The crystal fulfils and corrects §74. What is retrieved is not the hero but the hero's capacities, and what is handed down is not a destiny, the communal *Geschick* in whose name Heidegger's own retrieval led to that service, but a repertoire. Crystalline inheritance is retrieval without destiny, and the correction matters precisely because the destiny-form of inheritance has a history.

Gene Wolfe's *Book of the New Sun* (1980–1983) imagined a darker rite. A drug prepared from the alzabo, a beast that carries within it the voices of those it has devoured, allows those who eat the flesh of the dead to absorb their memories; Severian receives his beloved Thecla in this way, and the Autarch bears within him the minds of his predecessors. The crystal is the anti-cannibal form of Wolfe's rite. No flesh is eaten; the dead pass into the living as light. Wolfe's Autarch inherits by consumption. Ramza's company inherits by transmission.

10.5 Blood and crystal

Two economies of the dead now stand opposed. The Lucavi's economy is resurrection through blood. Ultima requires the blood of a war to rise in a new body, which is mythic violence in Benjamin's sense (Chapter 6) and the metaphysics of haemocracy (Chapter 1). The crystalline economy is transmission without blood. The dead do not rise; they disperse into the living as capacity. The first hoards, gathering the blood of thousands toward a single sovereign body; the second disperses, scattering one life among many heirs. The first requires sacrifice. The second requires only a choice.

Benjamin's sixth thesis, which stands among this dissertation's epigraphs, warns that even the dead will not be safe from the enemy if he wins. The game shows the enemy seizing the dead again and again. Argath, killed at Zeakden, is raised at Limberry as a puppet of the Lucavi. Zalbaag, killed by his brother become Adrammelech, is raised by Folmarv and set against Ramza in the sanctuary of Mullonde Cathedral, where, blind and in agony, he begs to be struck down. Barich, killed by Ramza, returns possessed in the Necrohol. Ajora's name is seized by the Church, and Ramza's presumed death by the official record, which converts it into absence. Against all this, crystallization is a defence of the dead. A crystallized unit cannot be reanimated, because it has already passed into its heirs; the undead, by contrast, are precisely those who never crystallize. The crystal withdraws the dead from the enemy by dispersing them among the living. It is the game's answer to Benjamin's warning.

Two complications test the distinction, and both refine it. At Riovanes, Rapha holds a Zodiac Stone over her dying brother, hears a voice urging her to use it, and, against Ramza's

warning, does; Marach lives. The 2025 remaster adds a second case, showing Ramza and Alma escaping the collapse of the Airship Graveyard by means of the auracite Ramza had gathered. Neither use is a pact. Rapha acts within the count, before death is complete, and the remaster's Ramza spends the hoard rather than accumulating it, turning the Church's capital of stones into a single act of rescue. What marks the petrific regime, then, is not the stone's power but its economy: the bargain of the self, and the accumulation of bodies and blood toward a sovereign. Power spent for the living, within the time of the living, belongs to the other economy, even when it flows through a stone.

10.6 Mourning and the reset

Permanent death gives the grid its moral weight; Miguel Sicart has argued that the ethical player is formed by consequences a game refuses to let him undo (*The Ethics of Computer Games*, 2009). Players have long answered permadeath with the reset, reloading a save to cancel a loss. Freud distinguished mourning, which accepts the loss of the object and slowly withdraws the libido attached to it, from melancholia, which refuses the loss, incorporates the lost object, and turns its reproach inward ("Trauer und Melancholie," 1917). The resetting player is melancholic in Freud's sense. He refuses the loss, rewinds time, and keeps the dead from crystallizing. Structurally, he also becomes Ultima: a sovereign who undoes death by rewriting time.

The player who lets the count run out and takes up the crystal mourns. *Final Fantasy Tactics* forbids neither choice. It makes the choice an ethical one, and it rewards the mourner with something the melancholic cannot have: an heir transformed by the dead. The ethics of play here is the ethics of mourning, which is to let the dead become crystal.

10.7 Crystalline historicity defined

The argument now permits a definition. *Crystalline historicity* is a mode of relation to the past in which the dead are neither resurrected, as in the Lucavi's economy and the Church's cult of its saint, nor commodified, as in the chest and in the archive conceived as a treasure-house, nor monumentalized, as in the official chronicle and Nietzsche's monumental history, but transmitted as capacity to a living inheritor who must choose to take it up, at the cost of the consolation the same inheritance could have afforded, and who is transformed in the taking.

It has five properties. It is *bloodless*: it requires no sacrifice. It is *dispersive*: it does not accumulate in a sovereign body. It is *elective*: inheritance is a task, not a fate. It is *self-consuming*: the crystal vanishes when taken, so that the dead persist not as relics but as powers in the living. And it is *protective*: it withdraws the dead from the enemy who would reanimate them.

The Durai Papers are the narrative's crystal. Ramza never crystallizes in play; he crystallizes only in the text, which offers its reader the choice the crystal offers the soldier.



Part Four

The Order of the Record

Veritas filia temporis.
Truth is the daughter of time.

Proverb after Aulus Gellius, who cites it from an older poet, *Noctes Atticae* XII.11.7

Chapter Eleven

The Chronicle of the Defeated

The Durai Papers and the Historiography of Ivalice

11.1 The papers and the pyre

The frame of *Final Fantasy Tactics* rests upon a short chain of facts. Orran Durai, astrologer and adopted son of Count Orlandeau, glimpses Ramza and Alma alive after the last battle, riding away on chocobos, when all believe them dead. He sets down what he knows of the war in the papers that bear his name; the Church brands him a heretic and burns him at the stake; the papers are confiscated and hidden in Mullonde, in the Church's own keeping. Centuries later his descendant, the historian who narrates the game, recovers them. Matsuno has since confirmed that Ramza and Alma survived, and the 2025 remaster shows how. The Japanese title of the document deserves attention. A *hakusho*, a "white paper," is the genre of the government's official report. The counter-history appropriates the state's own form of documentation. The heretic writes in the genre of the ministry.

11.2 The scriptural tomb

Michel de Certeau described historiography as a burial rite (*L'Écriture de l'histoire*, 1975). Writing gives the dead a place in discourse, and in giving them a place it both honours them and lays them to rest, freeing a space in which the living may act. History is a tomb in the double sense of monument and grave. The Durai Papers are a scriptural tomb for Ramza. But no grave holds him: those whom the war is presumed to have claimed are seen riding away. The empty tomb returns as historiographic undecidability: *"he is risen; he is not here: behold the place where they laid him"* (Mark 16:6). The gospel's empty tomb, witnessed first by a few, transmitted by a text, and founding a community, is the structure the Durai Papers repeat. Orran is evangelist and martyr; his text is a gospel of the heretic.

Tolkien named the sudden joyous turn of a story the *eucatastrophe*, and called the Resurrection the eucatastrophe of the story of the Incarnation ("On Fairy-Stories," 1947). The final image of *Final Fantasy Tactics* is a eucatastrophe granted to one witness and denied to history. The hero survives, but only as one forgotten.

11.3 The danger of the counter-gospel

The structure is dangerous, and the game knows it. A heretic's survival witnessed by one man, recorded in a book whose author is martyred, recovered centuries later by a devoted reader: this is the founding pattern of the Church the game indicts, with its founder, its witness, its text, its martyrdom, and its community of readers. The Durai Papers risk becoming a new scripture of Ajora. The frame's sobriety is the safeguard. Alazlam presents the papers as a document to be weighed rather than a revelation to be believed; he questions rather than proclaims. The game's historiography is self-limiting. It offers a counter-history that declines to become a counter-church.

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) ends with those who leave a city whose happiness depends upon a child's suffering, walking toward a place the narrator cannot describe. Ramza walks away; Orran writes back. The game requires both gestures, refusal and testimony, and it warns that the second may found another Omelas.

11.4 Against the grain

Benjamin's seventh thesis indicts the historian who empathizes with the victor and calls the spoils of the triumphal procession cultural treasures: *"Es ist niemals ein Dokument der Kultur, ohne zugleich ein solches der Barbarei zu sein."* There is no document of culture that is not at the same time a document of barbarism. The historical materialist, accordingly, *"betrachtet es als seine Aufgabe, die Geschichte gegen den Strich zu bürsten"*: he regards it as his task to brush history against the grain. The official chronicle of Delita is a document of culture. The Durai Papers expose the barbarism it carries: Tietra, the Death Corps, Ovelia, and the substitute bodies on which the reign was built.

The ninth thesis describes the angel of history, after Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus*. His face is turned toward the past, where he sees a single catastrophe piling wreckage upon wreckage at his feet. *"Er möchte wohl verweilen, die Toten wecken und das Zerschlagene zusammenfügen"*: he would like to stay, to awaken the dead and make whole what has been smashed. But a storm blowing from Paradise, the storm we call progress, drives him irresistibly into the future to which his back is turned.

The last battle of *Final Fantasy Tactics* is fought in the Airship Graveyard, a field of wreckage left by a vanished civilization, the same age of airships in which, by the Church's own legend, Ajora was born, and the enemy there is Ultima, the High Seraph: an angel who wishes precisely to awaken the dead, beginning with herself under the name of a saint, and to make whole what has been smashed, a body, out of the blood of a war. Ultima is the demonic double of Benjamin's angel. Where the angel of history cannot awaken the dead, the demon can, at the price of blood. Ramza's last act is to deny the false angel the resurrection the true angel cannot accomplish. The game thus distinguishes the messianic desire to awaken the

dead from its demonic counterfeit. Only the former is just, and it cannot be fulfilled by force. What Ramza does instead is leave the dead their death and the living their freedom, and then disappear into the storm.

11.5 Three uses of history, and the herd

Nietzsche distinguished three uses of history ("Vom Nutzen und Nachtheil der Historie für das Leben," 1874). Monumental history supplies models of greatness to those who act; antiquarian history supplies piety toward origins to those who preserve; critical history judges and condemns the past for those who suffer and need liberation. The Church's legend of the Zodiac Braves and the official history of Delita are monumental. The nobility's genealogies are antiquarian. The Durai Papers are critical.

But Nietzsche opened his essay not with history but with its absence: *"Betrachte die Heerde, die an dir vorüberweidet: sie weiss nicht was Gestern, was Heute ist."* Consider the herd grazing past you: it does not know what yesterday or today is, and, fettered to the moment, it is neither melancholy nor bored. The unhistorical, Nietzsche argued, is a condition of happiness and of action. The final image of *Final Fantasy Tactics*, Ramza and Alma riding away on their mounts while they are mourned, is the unhistorical in Nietzsche's sense: survival purchased by exit from history, a survival Matsuno has since confirmed and the 2025 text makes explicit. Happiness in Ivalice is available only to those whom history has forgotten. The cost of the Durai Papers' critical history is that it restores Ramza to the history from which his happiness depended on his absence. The gift of the papers is also a theft.

11.6 Emplotment

Hayden White argued that historical narratives are emplotted in one of four modes, romance, tragedy, comedy, or satire, and prefigured by the master tropes of metaphor, metonymy, synecdoche, and irony (*Metahistory*, 1973). The official history of Delita is a romance: the hero triumphs over adversity and restores the realm. The Durai Papers are a tragedy: the hero's fall discloses the law of the world. The game, which frames both, is ironic, the mode of a historiography conscious of its own emplotment.

White also distinguished annals, mere lists of dated events; chronicles, which order events without closure; and narrative histories, which impose an ending and with it a moral judgement ("The Value of Narrativity in the Representation of Reality," 1980). The game's encyclopedic *Brave Story* is a chronicle: it accumulates persons, places, and events without concluding. The Durai Papers are narrative history, and White's insistence that narrative closure is always moral judgement makes their moral explicit. The closure they impose is the verdict that the victor was not the hero.

The chronicle has a Japanese theory of its own. Ōtsuka Eiji argued in his theory of narrative consumption (*Monogatari shōhiron*, 1989), using the collectible stickers sold with a brand of chocolate, that consumers acquire small fragments of story in order to reconstruct the hidden worldview, the grand narrative, that the fragments imply. Azuma Hiroki, revising Ōtsuka a decade later (*Dōbutsuka suru posutomodan*, 2001), argued that grand narratives had collapsed into databases from which consumers assemble what they please without seeking any whole. He borrowed from Kojève, whose note of 1959 contrasted a post-historical American "animality" with a Japanese "snobbery" of pure forms, the figure of the post-historical animal. *Final Fantasy Tactics* stands at the hinge between the two diagnoses. Its *Brave Story* is a database in Azuma's sense, an inventory of persons, artefacts, wonders, and rumours that grows as the player collects. Yet the game insists, with Ōtsuka, that the fragments compose a hidden grand narrative, and it adds what neither critic supplies: the hidden narrative is a political truth that the official one suppresses. The game uses the database form to reassert a counter-grand-narrative.

The game also gives the unofficial record a place. In its taverns the company hears rumours of the war and of the realm's legends, and contracts errands on which idle members are sent away for days at a time, returning with pay, experience, and sometimes an artefact or a wonder for the chronicle. Jürgen Habermas located the origin of the bourgeois public sphere in such places, the coffeehouses, salons, and table societies in which private persons came together to argue about public matters (*Strukturwandel der Öffentlichkeit*, 1962). Ivalice's taverns are a public sphere before its time and a labour exchange at once: the company hires out its own members, as its members were once hired out to the crown, and the rumour that circulates over the same tables is the history of those who cannot write. Between the official chronicle and the heretic's papers lies this third record, oral, anonymous, and unreliable, which the game gathers without vouching for it.

11.7 Truth, the daughter of time

Hannah Arendt argued that factual truth is more vulnerable than rational truth ("Truth and Politics," 1967). A theorem, once lost, can be rediscovered; a fact, once lost, may be lost for ever. The modern political lie aims not merely to conceal a fact but to replace reality with an image, and the guardians of factual truth are the storyteller, the historian, and the judge. The Durai Papers wager that a single testimony can preserve a factual truth across centuries of official image-making.

Josephine Tey's *The Daughter of Time* (1951) stages the same wager as a detective story. Inspector Alan Grant, confined to a hospital bed, investigates Richard III through portraits and documents and concludes that the Tudor account of the princes in the Tower was propaganda. The novel's title is the proverb that serves as this Part's epigraph. Alazlam is Grant;

the official history is the Tudor myth; the Durai Papers are its Ricardian revision. The discovery of Richard III's remains beneath a car park in Leicester in 2012, and their reburial in 2015, completed the analogy in the actual world: history recovering a body the victors had lost.

The papers' survival has a precedent in the history of persecution itself. In the epilogue the Church confiscates the Durai Papers and hides them in Mullonde, and the remaster's opening narration adds that they had long lain concealed in Church archives: the counter-record survives because the institution that burned its author kept it. Historians of heresy know the paradox well. Emmanuel Le Roy Ladurie reconstructed the life of a Cathar village from the register of Jacques Fournier, the bishop-inquisitor who interrogated its people (*Montaillou*, 1975); Carlo Ginzburg recovered the cosmology of a sixteenth-century miller, Domenico Scandella, called Menocchio, from the records of the Inquisition that tried him and had him put to death (*Il formaggio e i vermi*, 1976). In both cases the voices of the persecuted survive only in the persecutor's archive. The Durai Papers are such an archive turned inside out. The petrific regime, which hoards in order to control, preserves in spite of itself the crystal that will undo it.

11.8 Requiem for the defeated

The Japanese traditions supply what the European ones lack, a historiography whose primary function is to console the defeated. The *Heike monogatari*, the chronicle of the fall of the Taira, was chanted by blind priests to the accompaniment of the biwa, and its performance had a ritual purpose: to pacify the spirits of the defeated dead (*chinkon*), whose resentment might otherwise afflict the living. The *Heike* is history as requiem. Its subject is the vanquished, its mood is impermanence, and its purpose is pacification. The Durai Papers are a *Heike* for Ramza. Their purpose is not to celebrate a victory but to give the defeated a place.

Orikuchi Shinobu named the narrative type *kishu ryūri tan*, the tale of the wandering noble: a youth of high birth exiled from his proper place, wandering in hardship, sometimes destined to return and often to perish, whose exemplars include Yamato Takeru, Genji at Suma, and Minamoto no Yoshitsune. Ramza's story is the type in its purest form. Yoshitsune, the brilliant younger brother who won the Genpei War for his elder brother Yoritomo and was then hunted by him to his death at Koromogawa in 1189, gave the Japanese language the expression *hōgan-biiki*, partiality for the Lieutenant (his court title), the habit of siding with the tragic loser. Legends grew that Yoshitsune had not died but escaped to the north, and Meiji-era fancy even made him Genghis Khan. The final glimpse of Ramza alive belongs to this tradition of survival legends, with one difference from Yoshitsune's: Matsuno has confirmed that Ramza and Alma survived, and the 2025 remaster shows them escaping, so that the legend has passed into the record. Ivan Morris traced the Japanese veneration of the sin-

cere hero who fails over the one who succeeds (*The Nobility of Failure*, 1975). *Final Fantasy Tactics* fuses the European grammar of Machiavelli and Benjamin with the Japanese aesthetics of noble failure. Ramza is the Yoshitsune of Ivalice: the younger brother destroyed by his elder brothers' order, beloved by the historiography of the losers, granted a survival legend.

11.9 A library of counter-histories

The game belongs to a library of counter-histories in speculative fiction, and its place on those shelves clarifies its argument. Glen Cook's *The Black Company* (1984) is written as the annals of a mercenary company kept by its physician, Croaker, who serves a dark power and records his own partiality; the game's second chapter, in which Ramza serves in Gaffgarion's company, is a Black Company episode, and the annal is the mercenary's form of memory. Gene Wolfe's Severian, a torturer's apprentice who becomes Autarch and writes his own history while claiming perfect memory, fuses Ramza and Delita in a single narrator and teaches the reader to distrust him. Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) imagines a monastic order preserving the relics of a destroyed technological civilization, with knowledge suppressed, recovered, and lost again in a cyclical history. Ivalice, whose machinists excavate the automata of a lost age at Goug and whose last battle is fought among the wrecks of airships beyond the Church's necropolis, is a post-catastrophic world of exactly this kind.

Umberto Eco's *Il nome della rosa* (1980) sets a forbidden book, the lost second book of Aristotle's *Poetics*, in the labyrinthine library of a monastery that kills to keep it. Beneath Orbonne Monastery lies an underground book storage of several levels, where Ramza contends with the Templars who carry off his sister; in both works the library is the threshold of the demonic. The game even supplies Eco's librarian. Simon, a former inquisitor, deciphered the Scriptures in Orbonne's underground library and kept them hidden, as Jorge of Burgos hides Aristotle's lost book on comedy, though Simon hid his book not to suppress laughter but to keep his library. Philip Pullman's *His Dark Materials* (1995–2000) makes its Magisterium the servant of the Authority, an angel who usurped the place of the creator; Ultima, the High Seraph who usurps a saint, is the Authority's sister. Akutagawa's "Yabu no naka" (1922) and Kurosawa's *Rashōmon* (1950) dramatize irreconcilable testimonies and an inaccessible truth. *Final Fantasy Tactics* is anti-Rashomon. It dramatizes the fragility of factual truth while refusing perspectivism. The game believes there was a Ramza.

11.10 The text's own afterlife

Benjamin wrote that translation belongs to the afterlife of a work, its *Überleben* and *Fortleben*: *"In ihnen erreicht das Leben des Originals seine immer erneute späteste und umfassendste Entfaltung"* ("Die Aufgabe des Übersetzers," 1923). In translations the life of the original attains its latest, continually renewed, and most comprehensive unfolding. The tex-

tual history of *Final Fantasy Tactics* repeats the fate of the Durai Papers. Its first English translation, notorious for its opacity, rendered much of the political argument nearly illegible to Anglophone players, a suppression produced by no censor but by the accidents of localization. The 2007 retranslation recovered the argument in an archaizing idiom, an invented early-modern English that aligned Ivalice with the Tudor stage, so that in English the War of the Lions was Elizabethanized and the counter-history came to speak in the diction of the Tudor myth it contests. The 2025 remaster continues the series of recoveries, and its revision is the author's own. Matsuno reworked almost the entire script for full voicing, likening the change to the difference between a novel and a play, and added new scenes; the remaster also resolves what the earlier texts left open, showing Ramza and Alma escaping the collapsing graveyard by means of the auracite he had gathered. Matsuno had already retold the story once, in the Return to Ivalice raids of *Final Fantasy XIV*, where Ramza himself asks Orran to strike his name from history. The author has become one of his own text's successive heirs, and the mourning-play has become, in the most literal sense, a play.

Borges's "Pierre Menard, autor del Quijote" (1939), whose word-for-word rewriting of the *Quixote* is judged richer than Cervantes's because composed three centuries later, describes the phenomenon: the same events, rendered again, mean differently. The game is itself a document recovered, retranslated, and argued over, a crystal taken up by successive heirs.



PART FIVE

Synthesis

Das wahre Bild der Vergangenheit huscht vorbei.
The true image of the past flits by.

WALTER BENJAMIN, "ÜBER DEN BEGRIFF DER GESCHICHTE," THESIS V

Chapter Twelve

Theses on the Crystallization of History

The preceding chapters have argued by reading. This chapter states the synthesis directly, in the numbered form Benjamin gave his last work, as eighteen theses on the crystallization of history. Each condenses an argument made above and points beyond the game to the questions it poses for any political community.

I. Every polity is an economy of its dead. What a community does with its dead (how it counts them, keeps them, speaks of them, and spends them) is the most reliable index of what it is. A constitution can be read in a cemetery. *Final Fantasy Tactics* is a treatise on this proposition written in the form of a war, and every system it contains, from the clock of the turn to the crystal on the ground, is a clause in that treatise. The question it puts to Ivalice, and through Ivalice to any polity, is not who rules but what is done, under that rule, with those who have died for it.

II. Haemocracy is rule by blood in two registers. Lineal blood legitimates; effusive blood purchases. In ordinary times the first suffices and the second is spent at the margins. When lineal blood fails at the summit (a dead king, an infant heir, a princess whose blood her captors deny), effusive blood is summoned to supply legitimacy, and war becomes a machine for converting spilled blood into right. The Lion War is that machine running at full capacity. Every crisis of succession is, in this sense, a crisis of blood, and every war of succession is a transfusion.

III. The demons are the metaphysics of the order, not intruders into it. The Lucavi, who require a war's blood to grow a sovereign body, are haemocracy seen from within. They are Gramsci's morbid symptoms of an interregnum made flesh, and Weber's disenchanted gods risen from their graves. Wherever the reproduction of a political order depends upon bloodshed, a demonology is at work, whether or not anyone believes in demons.

IV. The demon is optional. Delita never touches a stone and outlasts everyone who did. The darkest proposition of the work is not that politics is diabolical but that it needs no devil. Vi-

olence suffices; the diabolical powers Weber found lurking in all violence require no pact to be released. The Lucavi are an allegory of what politics does without them.

V. Sovereignty in Ivalice is vicarious. Power speaks through borrowed bodies: a princess told she is a counterfeit, a possessed cardinal, a girl chosen as a vessel, a commoner girl killed in another's place. Its true emblem is not the crowned king but the possessed host. The player's anonymous recruits, randomly named and endlessly replaceable, are the same economy on the grid, and the game makes the player its administrator.

VI. The Church is the ghost of a deceased order sitting crowned upon its grave. Its saint is a substitute, its legend an inversion, its relics prisons, its holy city a lid upon a necropolis. Its sole authority is the administration of memory. Its true enemy, therefore, is not the heretic who disbelieves but the historian who remembers otherwise, and that is why it burns the historian.

VII. The traitor is the only witness. Counter-history begins in disloyalty to the institution that controls the record. Germonik betrays the Church to the truth; Orran betrays the crown's history to the defeated. There is no history against the victors that is not, at its origin, a betrayal, and none that does not risk becoming, in its turn, a scripture.

VIII. There are two stones. The Zodiac Stone imprisons a power and awaits a host; the crystal releases a capacity and awaits an heir. The first hoards and the second disperses. The first is a capital that appreciates in blood; the second is a gift that vanishes when it is taken. Every institution of memory can be classified by which of the two stones it resembles.

IX. The petrific regime freezes history into constellation. It arranges the dead into a figure (the Braves, the hero-king, the martyred saint) and fixes the figure in stone, so that history appears as what Benjamin called the *facies hippocratica* of history, an *erstarrte Urlandschaft*, a petrified primordial landscape. The crystalline regime breaks the constellation into its points and hands them on, one by one, to those who will carry them. The task of re-constellating the past is accomplished in Ivalice not by drawing a new figure but by dissolving the figure into capacities.

X. The tactician has no proper place, and therefore only he requires a historian. The strategist has a place and keeps a chronicler; the tactician has nowhere, and is kept, if at all, by a friend's papers. History from below is the historiography of those without a *propre*, written by those who are themselves about to lose theirs.

XI. Time belongs to the tactician, place to the strategist. The visible future of the turn list is the strategist's dream of time made space. The tactician's art is to find within measured time the moment that is not on the schedule. The messianic arrest that Benjamin opposed to homogeneous time is, on the grid, the tactician's *kairos*; in the frame, it is the historian's papers, which halt the official chronicle at the moment of its danger.

XII. The Arithmetician is the end of Ivalice. When violence selects by attribute rather than by person, the distinction between friend and enemy dissolves into administration, and the most powerful art abolishes art itself: it needs neither ground nor timing, only a number. A medieval world that discovers calculation has discovered its successor.

XIII. The subject is a vector. Faith and Bravery, mutable by speech and bounded by exits into the cloister and the hearth, compose a minimal anthropology in which political existence is the zone between too much faith and too little courage. The economy of Ivalice pays its cowards in treasure and its believers in exile, and keeps for itself those who are moderately afraid and moderately devout.

XIV. Augustine's three presents are the three powers of the grid. Faith is *expectatio*, the present of things to come, and its magic must be charged. Bravery is *contuitus*, the present of things present, and its reactions are instantaneous. The crystal is *memoria*, the present of things past, and it must be taken up. A unit is a soul distended across three times, and the battle is the place where the three must be made to agree.

XV. Within three counts, resurrection; after them, inheritance. The game divides, with the precision of a creed, the time in which the dead may be restored by technique from the time in which they may only be inherited. Ultima's resurrection through blood is the demonic refusal of that line, and the player's reset is its domestic counterpart; the undead, who alone may rise again once the count has run out, are its form within the rules.

XVI. Inheritance is a choice between consolation and capacity. At the crystal the heir decides whether to use the dead for present relief or to carry them forward as the power to act. Crystalline historicity is the discipline of choosing the second, knowing that the first was also a good, and that it is forgone.

XVII. The hero survives only as one forgotten. The two riders glimpsed after the last battle, when all believe them dead, teach that happiness in Ivalice is the unhistorical, and that the historian who restores the hero to history restores him to the realm from which his happiness required his absence. The gift of the Durai Papers is also a theft, and the game asks its readers to accept both.

XVIII. To play is to be the intriguer; to finish is to be asked what one got. The ludic Trauerspiel binds its player to the sovereign's gaze, moving bodies, spending units, and reading the future as a schedule, and then returns to him the sovereign's question. The work is itself a crystal. To read it is to choose whether to be restored, and leave as one came, or to inherit, and leave changed.

Conclusion

"What Did You Get?"

The game ends with a question. A king who has won everything stands in the ruined chapel at Zeltennia with a wound in his side and his queen dead at his feet, beside the flowers he brought for her birthday, and asks his absent friend what he got, and what he himself got. The question is addressed to Ramza, who cannot answer, and through him to the player, who has also won.

The architecture of the work answers it. Gabriel Marcel distinguished being from having (*Être et avoir*, 1935) and observed that possession tends to turn upon the possessor, so that what we have comes in the end to have us. Delita got everything that can be had: a throne, a queen, a name in the chronicle, and a glory the archive would later revoke. He got nothing that can be transmitted. The text gives him no heir, his glory is counterfeit, and his queen's last act was a refusal. Ramza got nothing that can be had: no house, no name, no certain grave. He got everything that can be transmitted: a sister restored to herself, a friend's testimony, and a capacity that passes, centuries later, to the readers of a historian's papers. The answer to the question is the one the crystal gives on every battlefield of the game. What one gets is what can be inherited.

The form of the work makes this answer something experienced rather than merely understood. The ludic Trauerspiel binds its player to the position of the intriguer. To play well is to move bodies across a grid, to spend some so that others may win, to read the future as a schedule, and to calibrate one's own army so that the arithmetic of death falls only upon the enemy. The game asks its player to be Delita in method and Ramza in sympathy, and to read the whole as Alazlam reads it, across a distance of centuries. This is not ludonarrative dissonance, the incoherence Clint Hocking named in 2007 when a game's rules contradict its story. It is allegory in Benjamin's sense, a structure in which meaning lies in the gap between what is shown and what is done. The player who has won every battle arrives, like Delita, in a ruined chapel with flowers. The melancholy is procedural, and it is earned.

The form has a precedent in the dispute it continues. Carl Schmitt's *Hamlet oder Hekuba* (1956), subtitled *Der Einbruch der Zeit in das Spiel*, the intrusion of time into the play, argued against Benjamin that *Hamlet* rises above the mere play of the mourning-drama because historical reality breaks into it, in the figure of a queen whose guilt could not be staged and a

prince who could not act; the play becomes tragedy at the points where it cannot remain play. *Final Fantasy Tactics* builds that intrusion into its structure. The frame breaks into the play at the beginning and at the end, as the historian's voice and the papers' fate interrupt the battles with the claim that they happened and were lied about. Alexander Galloway proposed that video games are allegories of control, forms that teach their players the logic of the informatic systems that govern them (*Gaming: Essays on Algorithmic Culture*, 2006). *Final Fantasy Tactics* is an allegory of sovereignty in the same sense. It teaches the logic of rule by making the player rule, and then lets history intrude upon the play.

The contribution of this dissertation can be stated in five propositions. It has proposed *haemocracy* as a concept for polities whose legitimacy circulates through blood in two registers, and has shown how their crises substitute effusive for lineal blood. It has distinguished the *petrific* and *crystalline* regimes of the dead, and derived from their opposition a theory of *crystalline historicity*, a relation to the past as inheritable capacity rather than possessed fact or revered monument. It has read the mechanics of a game as propositions in political philosophy and political theology, co-equal with its narrative. It has identified the *ludic Trauerspiel* as a form. And it has placed *Final Fantasy Tactics* within a world literature of counter-history, showing that its originality lies in the fusion of a European grammar, from Machiavelli to Benjamin, with the Japanese historiography of the noble failure.

Several lines of further research follow. A reception study comparing the game's Japanese and Anglophone audiences across its three English texts would test the claim that translation re-enacts the fate of the Durai Papers. A comparative study of Matsuno's oeuvre, from the massacre at Balmamusa in *Tactics Ogre* to the Ivalice of *Vagrant Story* and *Final Fantasy XII*, would trace how the question of who authors history developed across a career. The 2025 remaster's revisions to the script deserve close philological comparison with both earlier texts. And the communities of players who have preserved, retranslated, and modified the game for nearly three decades are themselves a case of crystalline transmission in practice: heirs who took up a capacity and were changed in the taking.

The final image of this dissertation is the one the game repeats on every field. A body falls. A numeral counts down above it: three, two, one. Then, where a person had been, there is a small light on the ground, waiting to be chosen.

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Final Fantasy Tactics; Yasumi Matsuno; Hiroyuki Ito; Hironobu Sakaguchi; Ivalice; ludic Trauerspiel; crystalline historicity; haemocracy; petrific and crystalline regimes; vicarious sovereignty; tactical heresy; political theology; counter-history; counter-memory; mnemohistory; historiography of the defeated; philosophy of history; Walter Benjamin; Niccolò Machiavelli; Michel de Certeau; Carl Schmitt; Max Weber; René Girard; G. W. F. Hegel; Alexandre Kojève; Thomas Hobbes; Ernst Kantorowicz; Hannah Arendt; Simone Weil; Jacques Derrida; Friedrich Nietzsche; Pico della Mirandola; Jorge Luis Borges; Gnosticism; Judas traditions; heresy and inquisition; Faustian pact; demonology; disenchantment; scapegoat mechanism; mythic and divine violence; sovereignty and the exception; Wars of the Roses; Tudor myth; Hundred Years' War; *gekokujō*; *kishu ryūri tan*; *hōgan-biiki*; *Heike monogatari*; *chinkon*; procedural rhetoric; ludology; game studies; job system; Charge Time; Faith and Bravery; permadeath; mourning and melancholia; inheritance; translation and afterlife; speculative fiction; Japanese role-playing games.